

The job offer has now given an international dimension to Choudhary's grassroots campaign, bringing his efforts to restore the Ajnar River into the global spotlight.

LG confers lifetime awards on 5 artists



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's classical arts and cultural traditions epitomise that patience and perseverance are prerequisites for achieving the pinnacle of glory, and this is an important message for the younger generation.

Underlining this crucial point, Delhi Lt Governor (LG) TS Sandhu also called for stronger links to be built between young people and the country's cultural traditions through lectures, performances, workshops, and opportunities to learn directly from practitioners.

He made these remarks here on Saturday after conferring Legends of India Lifetime Achievement Awards 2026 on five distinguished artists, honouring their lifetime contribution to India's classical arts and cultural traditions.

The awardees included Guru Shri VP Dhananjayan and Guru Shanta Dhananjayan for their contribution to Bharatanatyam, Ustad Shahid Parvez Khan for his mastery of the sitar and Hindustani classical music, TH Vinayakram for Carnatic classical music, Margi Madhu for his contribution to India's theatrical traditions, and KS Radhakrishnan for his contribution to Indian sculpture.

The ceremony was attended by Chairman, Festivals Awards,

Legends of India, Ambassador Lalit Mansingh, Founder Chairman, Legends of India, Dipayan Mazumdar and guests.

Addressing the gathering, Sandhu said the occasion was not merely to honour individual artists, but to recognise the civilisational inheritance they represent and the living traditions they have sustained through a lifetime of discipline, imagination, and devotion.

Quoting Prime Minister Narendra Modi's remark that "culture is a sublime expression of a people, and the foundations of a society," he said India's classical music, dance, theatre, and visual arts are repositories of the nation's history, imagination, and collective memory, and serve as powerful instruments of social and cultural dialogue that transcend differences of language and background.

The LG said preserving these traditions has become even more important at a time when technology is changing how people communicate and consume information, but stressed that preservation cannot mean keeping culture frozen in the past. It must instead mean creating conditions in which tradition remains relevant, while giving the next generation opportunities to experience, learn, and reinterpret it, Sandhu said. He connected this idea to the

Shakti ki Saptdhara vision, particularly its emphasis on knowledge and cultural strength, saying India's rise must be accompanied by a confident cultural identity, rooted in heritage yet open to the world, one that can serve as a bridge between India and the global community and strengthen the country's soft power.

Speaking about the awardees, the LG said each represents a different tradition, but a common thread connects them: decades of discipline, dedication, and unwavering commitment to their craft, built through patience, practice, and mentorship. The LG said this holds an important lesson for the younger generation, that in a rapidly changing world, new skills are essential, but so are perseverance, depth, and dedication to one's craft, and called for stronger links to be built between young people and cultural traditions through lectures, performances, workshops, and opportunities to learn directly from practitioners.

Sandhu stressed that the preservation of culture cannot be left to artists and cultural institutions alone, and that families, educational institutions of Delhi, civil society, and the corporate sector all have a role to play in making India's heritage more accessible.

NDMC steps up night cleaning, deploys 300 workers ahead of BRICS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has stepped up sanitation operations across its jurisdiction ahead of the BRICS Summit 2026, deploying nearly 300 sanitation workers during the night shift along with 10 Mechanical Road Sweepers (MRS).

The move is aimed at completing the bulk of sweeping and waste-lifting operations during the night so that major roads and public spaces are cleaned before the morning rush. The summit is scheduled to be held at Bharat Mandapam on September 12-13.

According to NDMC, with the Summit expected to bring international delegates and visitors to the national



capital, the NDMC has identified cleanliness and civic presentation as key operational priorities.

Sanitation teams are being deployed across major roads, markets, public spaces and other important locations within the Council's jurisdiction. The arrangements had been planned to ensure that sanitation operations continued uninterrupted through the Summit period, with field teams and supervisory personnel maintaining close watch over cleanliness conditions.

During the night shift, sanitation teams undertake

sweeping, lifting accumulated and scattered waste, and emptying of bins and trolleys. Jet cleaning operations are subsequently undertaken in the early morning, with the morning shift attending to finishing work and any fresh sanitation requirements.

The NDMC has also strengthened cleaning arrangements in major markets, which are being attended to three times a day — during the morning, evening and night shifts. Main roads and other important stretches are being kept under continuous supervision.



According to officials, mechanised cleaning has been given greater emphasis as part of the preparedness plan. Besides the 10 MRS deployed during the night, 15 Gobbler machines are being deployed during the day at strategic locations for the collection of scattered waste and litter.

In addition, 11 pressure-jetting machines have been deployed for deep cleaning of roads, footpaths, market areas and other public spaces across the NDMC jurisdiction, as part of the intensified sanitation

arrangements. The mechanised operations have been supplemented by an increased deployment of sanitation workers for manual sweeping, particularly in market areas, pedestrian stretches and locations that require close manual intervention. NDMC has also intensified door-to-door waste collection in major markets and other high-footfall areas to prevent the accumulation of waste in public spaces. Trolley lifting has been organised in three shifts to ensure timely evacuation of collected waste, officials said.

Excise department auctions 2,000 seized vehicles for ₹5 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Government's excise department has auctioned over 2,000 seized vehicles, fetching ₹5 crore in revenue, and cleared over 5,000 pending chemical analysis reports bringing the backlog of its type to zero. The auction of vehicles seized under the Delhi Excise Act freed up space at police station premises and public land.

According to Chief Ministers' Office statement, more than 2,000 vehicles seized under the Delhi Excise Act had been lying for a long time outside police stations and on adjoining public land. The auction of vehicles seized under the Delhi Excise Act freed up space at police



station premises and public land. To address the issue, the Excise Department undertook a special disposal drive under the Delhi Excise Act. As part of the exercise, the process of seizure and public auction was streamlined and more than 2,000 vehicles were auctioned.

The action has also brought

significant economic and administrative benefits. Timely auction of the vehicles helped prevent further depreciation in the value of the seized assets and generated more than Rs five crore in revenue for the Government. The removal of the vehicles has also freed up space occupied in police station premises

and on public land. The process is continuing so that the remaining seized vehicles can be systematically identified and disposed of. The department is also looking to dispose of the remaining seized vehicles.

The excise department has, in parallel, undertaken a major administrative overhaul of the functioning of the Excise Control Laboratory. More than 5,000 old chemical analysis cases related to police cases had been pending at the laboratory. The department has disposed of all these pending cases, bringing the active backlog down to zero.

"Earlier, laboratory reports on seized liquor samples could take years to arrive. This often delayed the related

police investigations and subsequently affected the legal process. To address the situation, staff have been recruited against posts that had remained vacant for a long time, while the modernisation of the Excise Control Laboratory is also under way. Following these measures, chemical analysis reports are now being prepared and issued within days instead of years," the CMO said.

Faster access to chemical analysis reports is expected to directly benefit enforcement of excise laws and police investigations. According to the department, a faster testing system will strengthen excise enforcement and help develop an effective deterrent against the smuggling of illicit liquor.

CM Rekha inaugurates development projects in Shalimar Bagh, launches ₹2.84 crore road work

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday inaugurated several development projects and launched construction works in the Shalimar Bagh Assembly constituency. The projects will further strengthen sanitation arrangements, beautify parks and improve road connectivity in the area. The Chief Minister said the Government's aim was not to limit development to large projects, but to provide better facilities to every street, every colony and every citizen.

Taking an important step in the education sector, the Chief Minister inaugurated the construction of the school building in BB Block, Shalimar Bagh. This will give further impetus to the development of better educational facilities for students in the area. At the same time, work was launched in AF Block to replace the open overhead conductor with underground cables, making the electricity system safer and more



organised. In addition, work was launched to replace the open overhead conductor on the main road of C&D Block in Shalimar Bagh with underground cables. This will help make the area's electricity system safer and more organised.

The Chief Minister also launched the construction of a new road from Shri Guru Gobind Singh College in Pitampura to Ring Road. The road, being built at an estimated cost of around ₹2.84 crore, will improve connectivity in the area and make commuting more convenient for residents. She also

inaugurated a newly constructed toilet block at Nehru Camp in Haiderpur. In addition, she inaugurated a modern compactor at the SP-TP Block in Pitampura. The initiative will help make sanitation arrangements in the area more effective by strengthening modern waste management systems. The Chief Minister also inaugurated beautification and development works in three parks in YP Block and 10 parks in WP Block. These works focus on providing local residents with better, cleaner and more beautiful green spaces.

40-year-old beaten to death in early hours, one held; CCTV captures assault

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 40-year-old man was beaten to death in Delhi in the early hours of Sunday, with CCTV footage showing two men repeatedly assaulting him. The CCTV footage captures two individuals attacking another man in Mayur Vihar Phase 3 at around 3.30 am.

The victim was identified as Dharamvir alias Dhanua. He was rushed to Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital, where doctors declared him dead, a police officer said.

The police later apprehended one of the two accused, identified as Pradeep, 22, he said, adding that efforts are underway to arrest the second accused. The motive behind the assault and the complete sequence of events are being ascertained as part of the investigation the, police said.

The incident took place under the jurisdiction of the New Ashok Nagar police station.

The attack took place near a Durga temple, opposite a local MLA's office, police said. A security



guard at the spot tried to intervene and drive the attackers away.

However, the two men allegedly attempted to attack him as well. The guard then informed the police.

After receiving information, a Delhi Police team reached the spot, cordoned off the area and began an investigation. The victim was initially seen standing with the two men before they attacked him with wooden logs and sticks, police said. The victim,

believed to be around 40 years old, was allegedly attacked with sticks and wooden batons. Security guard Nandlal Yadav, who witnessed the incident, alleged that the two attackers were present at the spot and threatened him when he tried to intervene.

According to Yadav, he initially tried to rescue the victim but was outnumbered by the attackers. He then made a PCR call to alert the police. By the time police arrived, the victim had already

Govt holds roundtable on startup policy 2026, aims to back 10,000 ventures

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Sunday held a roundtable with leading startup founders, investors and industry representatives to seek suggestions on the implementation of its Startup and Incubation Policy, 2026, which aims to support more than 10,000 startups and generate over four lakh jobs.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, who attended the meeting, said Delhi has the talent, educational institutions, technology capabilities and large consumer market needed to emerge as a major startup and innovation hub. The roundtable was organised by the Department of



Training and Technical Education in collaboration with Youth for Governance at The Lalit in New Delhi. The discussions focused on the key provisions, implementation framework and proposed financial support of over Rs 400 crore under the

policy, besides measures to create a more supportive environment for startups, according to a statement.

"Delhi has talented youth, strong educational institutions, technological capabilities, a large market and the presence of leading indus-

tries, making it a natural hub for startups and innovation," the chief minister said.

She said the Government's objective was to ensure that young people get support for their ideas and innovations, while startups are able to create employment and contribute to economic growth. Under the policy, the Government plans to establish incubation centres in Delhi University colleges and schools, she said.

The chief minister said the Government would work with startup founders, investors, industry representatives, educational institutions and young people to make the implementation of the policy more participatory and outcome-oriented.

The chief minister said

Delhi's startup ecosystem should go beyond creating businesses and become a foundation for innovation, investment, employment generation and economic growth.

Education Minister Ashish Sood, who chaired the meeting, said the Government aimed to support and encourage more than 10,000 startups during its tenure and create employment opportunities for over four lakh youth through them. "Many of these entrepreneurs started their ventures in Delhi and successfully scaled them to a much larger level," Sood said, adding that their experience and suggestions would help the Government ensure effective implementation of the policy.

**Karur Vysya Bank**
Smart way to bank

Possession Notice (For immovable property)
Issued under Rule 8(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002
Whereas,
The undersigned being the Authorized officer of THE KARUR VYSYA BANK LIMITED under the Securitization & Reconstruction of Financial Assets And Enforcement of Security Interest (Second) Act, 2002 (Act 54 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a demand notice dated 26/02/2025 calling upon the **borrower Shri/Ms. Prayag Nirwal** to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs 9,75,594.57 (Rupees Nine lac seventy five thousand five hundred ninety four rupees and fifty seven paise only) within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.
The borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him under sub-section (4) of section 13 of Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on this the 02nd day of September of the year 2026;
The borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of THE KARUR VYSYA BANK LIMITED for an amount of Rs 7,86,689.75 (Rs. Seven Lakhs Eighty-Six Thousand Six Hundred Eighty-Nine and paise Seventy-Five Only) as on 31.07.2026 and interest thereon from 01.08.2026.
The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
House no 185, Entire Ground Floor without Roof rights pocket-14, sector -24, Rohini Northwest Delhi, Delhi-110085 **Bounded: On the North by:** Plot No 186 **On the South by:** Plot no 184 **On the East by :** Entry **On the West by :** Plot no 170

Place : Delhi
Date: 02/09/2026

FOR THE KARUR VYSYA BANK LIMITED
Sd/- Chief Manager & Authorized Officer

**VANI COMMERCIALS LIMITED**
Regd. Off.: 201, 2nd Floor, BMC House, N Block, Near Maruti Suzuki Arena, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001
CIN: LT74899DL1988PLC106425 PH: +91- 9560006230
Website: www.vanicommercials.com, Email ID: info@vanicommercials.com

NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that:
• The 39th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Company will be held on Wednesday, 30th September, 2026 at 11:30 A.M. through Video Conferencing/Other Audio-Visual Means ("VC/OAVM"), to transact the business as set out in the Notice of the meeting dated 27th September, 2026.
• The Company on Saturday, 5th September, 2026, completed the dispatch of Notice of AGM by electronic mode to those members whose email addresses are registered with the Company/Depository Participant(s) and Dispatch Physical Letters to those whose email address are not registered with the Company/ Depository Participant(s) as on Friday, 28th August 2026 the ("Cut-off Date").
• The Notice of AGM can be viewed/downloaded from the NSDL website www.evoting.nsdl.com. Physical copy of the same is available for inspection, during 10:00 A.M. to 12:00 Noon at the registered office of the Company.
• Pursuant to the provisions of Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 as amended by the Companies (Management and Administration) Amendment Rules, 2015 and Regulations 44 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulation, 2015 the Company is pleased to provide e-voting facility by National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) to its members in respect of the business(es) to be transacted at the AGM.
• The e-voting facility will be available from Sunday, 27th September, 2026 (09:00 A.M.) to Tuesday, 29th September, 2026 (05:00 P.M.) after which e-voting shall not be allowed.
• The Cut-Off date for determining the eligibility to vote through electronic means or at the AGM is Wednesday, 23rd September, 2026.
• Any person, who acquires shares of the Company and becomes member of Company after dispatch of the Notice of AGM and holding shares as on Cut-Off date, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.com. However, if you are already registered with NSDL for remote e-voting then you can use your existing user ID and password for casting your vote.
• Facility for Remote e-voting shall be available at the AGM. Members who have already cast their vote through Remote e-voting prior to AGM may also attend the AGM but shall not be entitled to cast their vote at the AGM.
• In case of any queries or issues regarding e-voting, please refer to the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for Members and e-voting user manual for Members, available at download section of www.evoting.nsdl.com or to contact Ms. Pallavi Mhatre, Senior Manager by sending request at Evoting@nsdl.com or call on: 022 - 4886 7000 and 022 - 2499 7000 or send a request to at.evoting@nsdl.com.

By the Order of the Board of Directors
For Vani Commercials Limited
Sd/-
Vishal Abrol
Managing Director
DIN: 06938389

Date: 05th September 2026
Place: New Delhi



(Left) Rescue operation underway, (centre) NDRF personnel carry a student rescued from the debris and (right) rescue operation underway after a 50-year-old five-storey building housing a boys' hostel collapsed in a congested bylane in Satya Niketan near Delhi University's south campus on Sunday

5 killed in 5-storey building collapse at Satya Niketan; rescue on war footing



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah, BJP president Nitin Nabin, Union Health Minister JP Nadda on Sunday spoke to Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and took stock of the situation following the collapse of a five-storey building in south Delhi's Satya Niketan, which left 5 dead and several others injured.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Lieutenant Governor Taranjeet Singh Sandhu, Chief Secretary Rajiv Verma, Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar, and MP Bansuri Swaraj rushed to the spot after the incident. The chief minister later visited AIIMS trauma centre to take an update on the treatment and health condition of the students and other people injured in the extremely tragic incident.

Union Home Minister Amit

Shah expressed his grief at the deaths. He said he spoke to the chief minister, the police commissioner, and the NDMA director general for an assessment of the situation on the ground. "The injured are being given all necessary medical assistance. Praying for the speedy recovery of all those injured," he wrote on X.

Reacting to the incident, Nabin said in a post on X, "The tragic building collapse in Delhi's Satya Niketan is deeply concerning. Spoke with Delhi CM Rekha Gupta to assess the situation." Nabin said relief and rescue operations are underway "on a war footing" and all possible efforts being made to provide immediate medical assistance to the injured. "Praying for the safety and well-being of all those affected in this difficult hour," the BJP national president added.

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu said



the Government has directed agencies to ensure swift rescue efforts. "Deeply concerned to learn of the building collapse at Satya Niketan, RK Puram. Have directed all concerned agencies, including Delhi Police, Delhi Fire Service and DDMA, to work in complete coordination to ensure swift rescue efforts on the ground. Praying for the safety and well-being of everyone affected. The situation is being closely monitored, and it will be ensured that every possible support reaches those in need," he wrote on X.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, who visited the spot of the incident in south west Delhi, said she was deeply concerned by the building collapse and that rescue work is being carried out on a war footing. Teams from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), Delhi Fire Services, Delhi Police, District Disaster Management

Authority (DDMA), MCD, Centralised Accident and Trauma Services (CATS), and Civil Defence were deployed at the site, the chief minister said. "Currently at the incident site in Satya Niketan, RK Puram, along with all concerned authorities, closely monitoring the rescue operation. All agencies are working in coordination, with every effort focused on the safe rescue. Relief and rescue operations are continuing on a war footing," she wrote on X.

"The adjacent building has been vacated as a precautionary measure. Every possible effort is being made to safely rescue those trapped and provide immediate assistance to the affected families. The situation is being closely monitored, and all concerned agencies are working in coordination. The safety and well-being of every citizen remain our highest priority," she said.

Ground shook, then rubble: Eyewitnesses, neighbours describe panic after collapse

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A "sudden tremor" sent residents of nearby buildings rushing out of their homes only to see the horror of a pile of rubble in place of the PG accommodation bustling with students in south-west Delhi's Satya Niketan on Sunday. Many scrambled to remove the debris with bare hands and whatever tools they could get after the collapse of the five-storey building, Hostel Daze, in the congested colony lined with private student hostels, eateries and shops near the heart of Delhi University's South Campus.

A local Rajen Chhetri, who works with the Delhi Police, said the building had around 15 rooms, with two to three students sharing each, and repair or construction work was underway in the basement. "Most of the students staying here are from Kerala, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh and study mainly at Motilal Nehru College, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharm College and Sri Venkateswara College. They were paying around Rs 12,000 per bed," Chhetri said.

"I have been living here for the last 20 years. Some construction work was going on in the basement, where water had started accumulating. The foundation was also extremely weak," he said.



Neighbours look on during a rescue operation on Sunday

Police said a PCR call was received at South Campus police station at 1.34 pm, following which eight fire tenders and multiple rescue teams were rushed to the spot.

"We felt a slight tremor in our house. It felt like the ground shook, like an earthquake. We ran outside," a resident said. With no immediate arrangements, residents began lifting heavy concrete slabs and clearing debris themselves in search of those trapped, he claimed.

The adjacent building also appeared to be at risk and was slightly leaning, the resident claimed, adding that around 50 to 60 students could still be inside the collapsed structure.

Around 35 to 40 students were staying on the upper floors and some of them were sleeping when the building collapsed, another resident said. Work was being carried out in the basement, he claimed, adding that he managed to step out only minutes before the collapse and sustained injuries. "As soon as I came out, the whole thing collapsed," he said.

Another resident said his nephew had narrowly escaped after crossing the building on his bike moments before it collapsed. The structure came down with a loud crash immediately after he passed, he claimed, quoting his nephew as saying, "It was a matter of seconds."

Most of the students staying in the PG were from Kerala, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh, another resident claimed, adding that many of those trapped were believed to be from Kerala.

Since it was Sunday, many students had not gone to college and were inside the PG, he said. Priyanka, who said she had lived in the area for the past 20-22 years, said that buildings in the locality were being constructed up to five or six floors. "Many houses have been converted into boys' PGs, with the owners shifting elsewhere. They simply name the properties as PGs, take the rent online and leave them to operate," she said.



Waterlogging, illegal construction blamed after hostel collapse

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Locals on Sunday complained of a persistent waterlogging problem, alleged unchecked construction and "apathy" of building owners and civic agencies in southwest Delhi's Satya Niketan area after a five-storey building housing a boys' PG collapsed on Sunday afternoon. While the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) said it could not verify whether work was underway until the debris was cleared.

According to officials, the MCD has evacuated tenants from the building housing a girls' PG adjoining the collapsed building and sealed it.

The waterlogging worsened with incessant rains over the past two days and repair and construction work was underway in the basement of the building, they claimed as rescuers struggled to pull out the trapped students — believed to be around 30-40.

Every year, new students arrive in the congested colony from outside the

national capital looking for economical accommodation near Delhi University's South Campus, but, locals claim, most of the building owners who do not stay in the area do not care about the condition of the structures. Nor does the MCD, they said.

The five-storey structure, which housed a boys' hostel, was a nearly 30-year-old G+4 building constructed on an area of around 55 square yards in a resettlement colony where permission was granted only for a G+1 unit, a senior MCD official said. The official said the collapsed building violated norms and was only allowed to build a ground floor plus the first floor.

"New academic session mein repaint karte hain (they only repaint the building at the start of the academic session), so how will we know and find out if a building is dilapidated? MCD koi inspection nahi karti," a local claimed.

The residents claimed that an MCD office was located next to the collapsed building. They said that a building,

which was under construction in a lane behind the collapsed structure and was intended to be used as a girls' PG, collapsed around two years ago and has remained in the same condition since then.

MCD Deputy Commissioner (South) Rakesh Kumar said the civic body has vacated and sealed the building adjoining the collapsed structure after it was found to be in a dilapidated condition. "The structure next to the collapsed building appears to be in a dilapidated condition. It has been sealed and will be demolished. All the tenants in the next building have been shifted to the nearest community hall," he said.

Kumar said two hydra machines, four JCBs, around half-a-dozen pickup trucks and 30-40 MCD personnel were deployed at the site after the incident.

Asked about reports that repair work was underway in the basement, he said the debris had not yet been cleared and there was no way to ascertain whether any such work was taking place.

DU deeply pained by collapse; student groups demand safety audit of PGs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University on Sunday said it was "deeply pained" by the collapse of a paying guest accommodation in Satya Niketan, even as students' and teachers' outfits demanded a safety audit of such housing facilities across the city.

"We are deeply pained and saddened by the building collapse in Delhi's Satya Niketan. Our thoughts are with the students and families affected. We pray for the safe rescue of all those trapped and stand ready to support our students in every possible way," the varsity said on X.

The National Democratic

Teachers' Front (NDTF), Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), National Students' Union of India (NSUI) and Students' Federation of India (SFI) raised concerns over the violations of safety norms that may have led to the building collapse.

The ABVP staged a massive Protest outside the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) headquarters over student safety. The NDTF said the incident raised serious concerns over structural compliance and fire safety norms at private hostels and paying guest accommodations around the two Delhi University campuses and its colleges elsewhere.

It also flagged narrow lanes in several student res-



idential areas, saying these could hamper rescue operations during emergencies, as it demanded a time-bound inquiry into private hostels and PG accommodations around DU.

The ABVP staged a protest outside the Municipal Corporation of Delhi building over the collapse, alleging negligence by civic authorities and demanding a safety audit of student accommo-

datations across the city.

The RSS-backed outfit said its activists entered the MCD complex and staged a sit-in.

ABVP national general secretary Virendra Singh Solanki said the incident raised "severe questions" about the functioning of the city authorities. "A high-level probe must be initiated to ensure strict action against errant PG operators as well as the officials who permitted such unorganised PGs to run," he said.

The Congress-backed National Students' Union of India alleged negligence as the cause behind the collapse and demanded that the Delhi University administration and the Government carry out rescue operations on a war footing.

Opposition slams Government, says student safety must be ensured

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress and the Aam Aadmi Party on Sunday attacked the Modi Government after a building housing a boys' PG collapsed in southwest Delhi's Satya Niketan area, with Rahul Gandhi asserting that every student's life is precious and their protection must be ensured under all circumstances. In a post on X in Hindi, Rahul said, "The news of the building collapse in Satya Niketan, Delhi, is extremely heartbreaking and alarming. Reports indicate that several people are trapped under the debris, including many students from Delhi University."

"My appeal is that NDRF, Delhi Fire Service, and all rescue teams reach every single student by making every possible effort, ensuring that the injured receive the best possible immediate treatment, so that no effort is spared in



saving anyone," he said.

Congress and NSUI workers are present at the scene and are ready to provide every possible assistance, the leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha said. In this hour of difficulty, we all stand with the victims and their families. Students' lives were already filled with struggles. Now the situation has turned life-threatening. Due to the lack of good hostels in colleges or universities, students are forced to live in PG



accommodations, 40-40 at a time under one roof, in inhumane conditions. Every student's life is precious, and their protection must be ensured under all circumstances," Rahul said.

Congress National President Mallikarjun Kharge tweeted, "The building collapse in Delhi's Satya Niketan is a deeply distressing and avoidable tragedy. Reports of DU students being trapped under the debris are extremely worrying. Every



effort must be made to rescue those trapped and ensure the best possible treatment for the injured. NSUI workers and Congress leaders are already on the ground, helping students, victims and their families in every possible way. We stand firmly with them in this difficult hour. This tragedy also exposes the unsafe, overcrowded PGs students are forced to live in due to inadequate hostel facilities. Students come to Delhi to

build their future, not risk their lives for a roof over their heads. Every student's life is precious."

AAP National Convener Arvind Kejriwal, in a tweet in Hindi, said, "The incident of the building collapse in Satya Niketan, Delhi, is extremely tragic and alarming. I pray to God that the people trapped in the debris are rescued safely and quickly. Due to the Government's negligence in Delhi, many such accidents have already occurred. The Government must wake up from its slumber. There is a need to take large-scale action to ensure the safety of citizens."

Delhi Congress chief Devendra Yadav said the news of the PG building collapse at the South Campus (Satya Niketan) of Delhi University and students being trapped under the debris is deeply disturbing and raises serious questions about the Government's policies.

IN FOCUS



An artist paints an idol of lord Ganesha ahead of the Ganesh Chaturthi festival in Mumbai on Sunday

PTI

CM Yogi reviews flood situation, targets SP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chitrakoot

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday conducted an aerial survey of flood-affected areas here and distributed relief material to people and handed over land allotment to certificates to families made homeless by the floods.

Addressing a gathering in flood-hit Chitrakoot, Adityanath claimed that the quality of flood relief changed after his Government came to power. Before they were getting “dry bread” while, now the Government provides a comprehensive relief package of 50 kg with 26 items.

He alleged that the previous Samajwadi Party government did not pay any attention to the floods and “SP goons” would loot the entire relief amount meant for victims.



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath conducts a ground inspection of the flood-affected ghats in Chitrakoot

PTI

“Chitrakoot has faced the tragedy of floods before as well. Before 2017, whenever floods came, the then government did not take notice of the situation. All the money was eaten up by ‘SP goons’. Swallowed the entire thing. The poor, the weak

and the deprived got nothing,” Adityanath said.

“If someone raised concern, dry bread was given to them. This was the situation,” the chief minister said.

He was addressing a gathering after an aerial survey of areas affected by the recent

flooding of the Mandakini river and inspection of damage in and around Ramghat. The chief minister distributed relief material among 800 flood-affected families and handed over land-allotment certificates to families rendered homeless in the floods, along with financial assistance from the State Disaster Response Fund.

Recalling his visit to flood-hit areas after becoming chief minister in 2017, Adityanath was informed by officials at the time that “dry bread” was being given as relief to the flood-affected people.

“I immediately told the officials: If I give you only dry bread for 10 days, will you be able to survive? If you cannot, why should our people survive on it?” he said.

He said his Government subsequently decided to provide a comprehensive relief kit to every flood-affected

family. “Whatever we decided in 2017, we have continued. If a family is affected by floods, whether water remains there for a week or even for a day, that family should receive relief,” he said.

The chief minister said the relief package being distributed contains around 26 items and weighs nearly 50 kg.

“Earlier, people did not even get 1 kg. Today, around 26 items weighing nearly 50 kg are being provided so that the affected people get relief,” he said. Adityanath assured the flood-hit people that the government would stand by them in the hour of crisis.

“Today, I have come with relief material as well as to assure you on behalf of the double-engine BJP government that in this hour of disaster, you are not alone. The government, along with crores of BJP workers, stands with you,” he said.

He said the government would conduct a survey to assess damage to crops and provide relief accordingly.

“Whatever damage has been caused to crops will also be surveyed. Orders have been issued for the survey and relief will be provided accordingly,” he said.

The chief minister also assured people that damaged roads would be repaired. “Whether it is an ordinary family, a trader, a monastery or temple, or a ghat, whatever damage has been caused, the government will make arrangements to provide assistance to all of them,” he said.

He stressed on the need to protect river’s natural flow. Adityanath said the recent flooding of the Mandakini had highlighted the need to prevent construction and encroachment in the river’s catchment area.

CM Shivakumar calls for deeper Indo-US ties in tech, innovation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar on Sunday called for deeper India-US cooperation in technology, education, innovation, research, investment and culture, pitching Bengaluru as a key technology and innovation hub in the strategic partnership between the two countries.

Addressing an event marking the 250th anniversary of American independence, in the presence of US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor, Shivakumar said the India-US relationship was moving beyond traditional government-to-government engagement, with universities, scientists, entrepreneurs, startups and businesses playing an increasingly important role.

“Washington and New Delhi may guide the strategic partnership between our countries. But Bengaluru and Silicon Valley give it a



powerful technological dimension,” he said.

Shivakumar said Karnataka was keen to expand cooperation with the US in artificial intelligence, semiconductors, aerospace, advanced manufacturing, digital technologies and scientific research.

“Karnataka’s ambition is to be among those who shape, build and lead the technologies of tomorrow,” he said.

Opponents trying to defame me: CM Mann

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bathinda

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday alleged that the opposition leaders are trying to defame him and looking for an opportunity “to loot Punjab once again after years of filling their own coffers”.

During a “Lok Milni” programme at Ghudda village in Bathinda, he claimed that the opposition is troubled because his government is spending money for people’s welfare.

Taking on the BJP and Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), CM Mann said that the two erstwhile allies are once again moving towards an alliance.

He said while some leaders belonged to the “Modi quota” and others to the “Rahul Gandhi quota”, he alone belonged to the people’s quota.

Mann alleged that the opposition parties had a “dubious track record of



working against Punjab and its people” and could never be forgiven for their actions.

“The BJP has always adopted an anti-Punjab mindset and treated the state unfairly on issues concerning its rights and interests. Whether it is the issue of Panjab University, Chandigarh, Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB), the Sutlej Yamuna Link (SYL)

canal, the Harike canal, Republic Day tableaux, Rural Development Funds (RDF) or border area funds, the BJP has always treated Punjab unfairly,” he added.

The chief minister alleged, “The hands of the BJP are drenched with the blood of more than 700 farmers of Punjab who attained martyrdom while protesting against the draconian farm

laws. The people of Punjab will never forget this.”

Reminding the people of the track record of the Congress, he said “it was the same party which had rolled tanks into Sri Akal Takht Sahib”.

“Despite remaining in power in Punjab, the Congress did nothing to check the drug menace that spread during its tenure. The Congress also failed to punish those responsible for sacrilege incidents in the state,” he claimed.

“The Congress has no moral right to seek the trust of Punjabis. It is the same party that used tanks against Sri Akal Takht Sahib and witnessed the killing of innocent Sikhs across the country. When the Congress was in power in Punjab, drugs spread among the youth, but the party did nothing to stop this menace. Even in sacrilege cases, the Congress failed to deliver justice. Punjab cannot forget this history,” Mann said.

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Shah unveils roadmap for drug-free India...

Since 2019, he said, the government has improved systems, broken up networks, disrupted financial links, and increased support for victims.

The 2026- 2029 roadmap rests on four pillars: intelligence- and operations-based enforcement; control of precursor chemicals and synthetic drugs; demand and harm reduction; and capacity building and coordination. Under enforcement, the government has set targets of dismantling 100 international and inter-state drug networks, bringing back 100 narcotics-related fugitives and destroying 100 clandestine laboratories.

The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) and state agencies will investigate finances in every major drug case and create files on major offenders. To reduce demand, the campaign plans to reach 50 crore people. One lakh “Nashamukti Mitras” will be trained through the NCC, NSS, and My Bharat programs. Schools and colleges will be made drug-free, and the number of de-addiction centres will be increased to 1,751, with support from about 10,000 volunteers.

Every state will have a fully equipped Anti-Narcotics Task Force (ANTF) by March 2027, with full support from the central government for training and resources. Forensic reports will be given within 30 days. Shah pointed to drug seizure numbers to show stronger action: 26 lakh kilograms of drugs were seized from 2004 to 2014, compared to over 1.19 crore kilograms from 2014 to 2026.

Shah compared the fight against drugs to other security challenges. He said terrorism in Jammu and Kashmir is almost gone and the region is developing. In the Northeast, over 10,000 young people have given up arms. Naxalism, which lasted for fifty years, “has become a thing of the past.” Shah said, “We have eradicated Naxalism and will deal with the menace of narcotics in the same manner.”

The Home Minister praised Goa for implementing the three new criminal laws, saying the conviction rate has increased from 22 per cent to 53.2 per cent. He also mentioned the 1930 helpline as a useful tool against cybercrime and asked the media and public to support the national anti-drug campaign. Shah said he is confident that the whole country will support the three-year effort to protect India’s youth and achieve the goal of a developed nation by 2047.

JMM leader Sudivya Kumar dies at 56

He also met the members of the bereaved family and conveyed his condolences. Gangwar expressed deep grief over Kumar’s untimely death, describing it as a painful loss for Jharkhand. He said the minister’s demise had caused a significant loss to the state.

The death of Sonu has sent shockwaves through the JMM family, as he was close to Chief Minister Hemant Soren. Chief Minister Hemant

Soren, on receiving the death of Sonu’s death, posted in X handle, “Late last night, I received the sad news of the demise of my elder brother, our beloved Sudivya Kumar Sonu Ji. Accepting this news is extremely difficult for me. Sonu Bhaiya’s departure has left a void in my life that is impossible to express in words.”

“For me, Sonu Bhaiya was not just a senior colleague or a political associate. He was like an elder brother—someone who gave affection, guided me, and stood by my side steadfastly through every difficult time. The moments spent with him and the lessons learned from him will always stay with me,” Soren posted on his X handle.

Sudivya Kumar Sonu was associated with JMM for nearly three decades. In 1989, he became a primary member of JMM. Following that, in 1992, he became the founding president of the Giridih City JMM. He contested the assembly elections on a JMM ticket for the first time from Giridih in 2009. He contested from Giridih again in 2014, finishing in second place. However, in 2019, he won the Giridih Sadar Assembly seat for the first time. He went on to win again in the 2024 elections.

As the Minister of Higher Education, Sudivya Kumar Sonu played a key role during the JPSC-JSSC dispute by interacting directly with students. He communicated government decisions regarding student grievances, exam reforms, and investigations to the students. He played a crucial role in cancelling and postponing several JPSC-JSSC examinations, as well as initiating CID investigations.

Meanwhile, the Jharkhand government has declared a two-day state mourning in honour of senior JMM leader and minister Sudivya Kumar, who died on Sunday morning. The state government has also cancelled all its scheduled programmes during the period.

All Jharkhand government offices will remain closed on September 7, according to an official notification. “The state government has decided to observe two days of state mourning on September 6 and September 7, following the death of Minister Sudivya Kumar this morning,” it said. The national flag will be flown at half-mast on all buildings in Jharkhand where it is regularly flown, the statement said.

Nepal floods: 1,344 dead, 5,000 still missing

Only 98 bodies had been identified and handed over to their families, according to NDRRMA.

Identifying the dead has emerged as a major challenge, with many bodies recovered after being swept downstream, severely damaged, decomposed or recovered only in parts. The police have said that bodies carried far from the disaster sites and those that remained in water and mud have made identification particularly difficult.

Nepal Police has begun collecting DNA samples from relatives of missing people to help identify unclaimed bodies and human remains recovered after the floods. Relatives in Nepal can provide samples through the Nepal Police Hospital in Kathmandu or their nearest district police office.

Owaisi attacks Rajasthan Govt over civic amenities, infrastructure

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi on Sunday attacked the Rajasthan government over the condition of Jaipur’s Walled City, alleging poor sanitation, roads, sewerage and basic civic amenities.

Owaisi said he saw garbage, broken roads and potholes while entering the old city, which is recognised as a UNESCO World Heritage site.

Citing CAG reports, he alleged that only 11 to 25 per cent of urban waste in Rajasthan was being processed and questioned the utilisation of unspent municipal funds.

He also raised concerns over the condition of government schools, claiming that thousands of school buildings and classrooms required reconstruction or major repairs. Referring to a recent school wall collapse



in Ajmer, he asked who was responsible for children’s safety. Owaisi also criticised the state government over women’s safety and healthcare, citing official figures on rape cases and alleged deficiencies in government hospitals.

Questioning the government’s investment claims, he sought details of projects that had actually become operational and the number of jobs created, saying MoUs should not be equated with actual investment.

5 dead after building collapses in Delhi

Repair work was underway in the basement of the structure, which was used as a paying guest (PG) accommodation, when it collapsed at around 1.30 pm, a senior officer said. Locals claimed that the collection of water over days of rain in the basement had weakened the building’s foundation, leading to its eventual collapse. Locals claimed that the collection of water over days of rain in the basement had weakened the building’s foundation, leading to its eventual collapse.

Locals mentioned water collecting in the basement, a weak foundation, and insufficient support for the upper floors after recent renovations that added more rental space.

Eyewitnesses said the collapse felt like a sudden tremor or earthquake. After a loud rumble, a cloud of dust and debris filled the area as the building fell. Some students were sleeping on the upper floors at the time. People heard cries of “save us, save us” from under the rubble, and several trapped students called friends and family for help.

One student, Aditya Kumar, shared a short video from beneath the debris showing his dust-covered face and the wreckage around him. Locals started pulling away concrete slabs by hand before rescue teams arrived. In a strong show of community support, residents used a quick-commerce app to order oxygen cylinders and supplied air through gaps in the debris.

By evening, reports confirmed three deaths and three people admitted in critical condition at AIIMS Trauma Centre. Eleven people had been rescued and taken to the hospital. Officials estimated that 30 to 50 students might still be trapped, but the exact number was not confirmed as authorities checked occupancy records.

As a precaution, an adjacent building that seemed to be leaning was evacuated. Narrow, crowded lanes in the student neighbourhood delayed the arrival of some heavy equipment.

Delhi Police got a PCR call at South Campus station at 1:34 pm. Teams from the Delhi Disaster Management Authority, National Disaster Response Force, Delhi Fire Service, Delhi Police, Municipal Corporation of Delhi, and Civil Defence arrived at the site with fire trucks, ambulances, sniffer dogs, and machinery. The joint Commissioner of Police (New Delhi Range) and senior officers from the South-West district supervised the rescue operations. Police have registered a case and booked the building owner, Anand Bansal, who lives in Gurugram and runs several PG properties in the area. Bansal is said to be absconding.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Lieutenant Governor Taranjeet Singh Sandhu, Chief Secretary Rajiv Verma, Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar, Delhi Ministers Kapil Mishra, Ashish Sood and MP Bansuri Swaraj rushed to the spot after the incident. Union Home Minister Amit Shah was in Goa to inaugurate the BJP’s new state headquarters at Chimbhel near Panaji. He cut short the event after hearing about the collapse. Union Home Minister Amit Shah expressed his grief at

the deaths. He said he spoke to the chief minister, the police commissioner, and the NDMA director general for an assessment of the situation on the ground. “The injured are being given all necessary medical assistance. Praying for the speedy recovery of all those injured,” he wrote on X. Shah spoke with the Delhi Chief Minister, the Delhi Police Commissioner, and the NDRF Director General. He said he was deeply distressed and that intensive rescue operations were underway, with medical help being given to the injured.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visited the site and said that rescue work was happening urgently, with every effort being made to save those trapped and help affected families. The chief minister said that, after being taken to hospital, three students have died so far, and 11 have been rescued; rescue operations are going on. She asserted that stringent action will be taken against those responsible. She later visited AIIMS and spoke to students.

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu called for coordinated action. Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood expressed concern and confirmed that relief measures were in place. Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant also announced that the formal function would be shortened.

This incident has once again brought attention to ongoing concerns about old buildings being turned into student hostels in unauthorised or poorly regulated areas. It also highlights issues with illegal or poorly supervised structural changes and the pressure on civic enforcement in crowded university neighbourhoods.

An investigation into the exact cause and any lapses in building permissions or inspections is expected. As night fell, rescuers kept searching the rubble, working quickly to reach anyone who might still be alive under the collapsed floors.

President, PM expresses grief

Delhi CM Rekha Gupta, Lieutenant Governor Taranjeet Singh Sandhu, Chief Secretary Rajiv Verma, Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar, and MP Bansuri Swaraj rushed to the spot after the incident.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah expressed his grief at the deaths. He said he spoke to the chief minister, the police commissioner, and the NDMA director general for an assessment of the situation on the ground. “The injured are being given all necessary medical assistance. Praying for the speedy recovery of all those injured,” he wrote on X.

Reacting to the incident, Nabin said in a post on X, “The tragic building collapse in Delhi’s Satya Niketan is deeply concerning. Spoke with Delhi CM Rekha Gupta to assess the situation.” Nabin said relief and rescue operations are underway “on a war footing,” and all possible efforts are being made to provide immediate medical assistance to the injured.

“Praying for the safety and well-being of all those affected in this difficult hour,” the BJP national president added.

GRAPEVINE

Why no bidders for coalgasification?

Govt's much hyped ₹40,000 crore-worth Coalgasification project failed to attract any bidders. No private bidder from the steel and coal industry has submitted a bid, and the last date is September 7. The Government is consulting public sector company heads to save face and asking why none is interested. The grapevine is that most of the tender norms are not suitable for the current scenario in the coal gasification project.



GDP vs disgruntled former finance secretary

In the past few days, panic has been seen in the Government to find apt persons to challenge the data presented by former Finance Secretary Subhash Chandra Garg. Many retired top Finance Ministry officials decided not to challenge the retired colleague questioning the GDP data. At last, serving officials were pressed into service to support the Govt's claims on a GDP increase of 7.8 per cent.



Restless secretaries

The restlessness within the top bureaucracy seems to have resurfaced. A couple of months ago, major changes were effected as in one case the Minister was annoyed with the working style of his Secretary, while in another the Secretary had complained against his Minister. The tug of war led to even the repatriation of top IAS officers to their respective States. Now, the grapevine has it that two Secretaries at the Centre have conveyed to their reporting boss a request for a change in their departments/ministry as both of them expressed their inability to perform under their Ministers, which includes a woman. Amongst the two Ministers in question, one of them was taken to task in the review meeting of the Council of Ministers chaired by the Prime Minister in May 2026.



BRS to raise Kaleshwaram, Palamuru projects, fee dues in Assembly: KCR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Hyderabad

BRS president K Chandrasekhar Rao directed party MLAs and MLCs to raise the Congress Government's alleged failure to release water from the Kaleshwaram project and neglect of the Palamuru-Ranga Reddy irrigation project during the monsoon session of the legislature beginning Monday. They will also raise the issue of pending dues under the tuition fee reimburse-

ment scheme, among other matters, he said. Rao, also known as KCR, who presided over a meeting of party MLAs and MLCs to finalise the party's strategy for the session on Sunday, announced that he would soon launch "agitations with lakhs of people" against the Congress Government's alleged negligence in releasing water from the Kaleshwaram project and completing the Palamuru-Ranga Reddy irrigation project. The Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation Project has faced controversy over structural

CBI arrests 5 more in digital arrest crackdown

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

■ New Delhi

In its nationwide operation called 'Operation Chakra-VI', the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has now arrested five more people accused of carrying out 'digital arrest' frauds, bringing the total number of arrests in the three high-value cases to eight. The agency stated that these most recent arrests are helping it to get closer to identifying the organised networks responsible for these scams. Fraudulent individuals who pretend to be members of the police or other authorities keep the victims isolated during video conversations for weeks or even months and force them to transfer large amounts of money. Following the Supreme Court's direction, which had previously highlighted the extent of such offences, the CBI had already carried out coordinated searches at 89 sites across 20 States as part of three major cases. There is one instance of a person linked to BITS Pilani who was subjected to a digital arrest for three months and suffered a loss of ₹7.67 crore; in Gujarat another victim was also detained for three months and lost ₹19.24 crore; in Karnataka a third case involved a victim being digitally detained for a month and being cheated out of ₹15.45 crore; the total losses in the three cases amount to more than ₹42 crore. Three people had already been arrested as a result of the previous searches. The man from Haryana, Akash, was paid ₹1.95 crore into an account, which he then transferred on the same day. Raja Karmakar from Kolkata was



Jhiram Valley attack case: Why did Congress not submit evidence to probe agency, asks Chhattisgarh CM Sai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Raipur

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Sunday hit out at the Congress over its criticism of the NIA court verdict in the 2013 Jhiram Valley Maoist attack case, and asked why the party did not submit any evidence of its claims to the probe agency. Political statements cannot change the truth, Sai said in a statement. An NIA court in Jagdalpur on Saturday convicted all 10 accused arrested in connection with the attack, in which 29 people, including senior Congress leaders Vidya Charan Shukla and Mahendra Karma, were killed. The court has fixed September 16 for pronouncing the quantum of punishment. The deadly attack took place on May 25, 2013, when Maoists ambushed the Congress' 'Pariwartin Rally' on a national highway in Jhiram Valley under Darbha police station limits in Bastar district. Reacting to the verdict, senior Congress leader and former chief minister Bhupesh Baghel had described it as "incomplete justice", saying the alleged larger political conspiracy behind the attack had not been investigated. State Congress president Deepak Baij had said the conviction of 10 accused was not justice for Bastar, the victims' families or the Congress. Responding to the criticism, Sai said the case was handed over to the NIA when the Congress-led UPA Government was in power at the Centre. "The investigation and judicial process continued for nearly 13 years. More than 100 witnesses were examined and the court delivered its verdict after examining all the facts and evidence. The court has convicted 10 people and will determine their punishment on September 16," Sai said. He said the Congress should also remember that the NIA is the country's premier investigation agency and not an agency of any State Government.



Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai

Swatantra Bhardwaj questioned by multiple teams during police remand

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Self-proclaimed Hindutva influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj, arrested in connection with the alleged assault on a student activist's father during a protest at Delhi's Jantar Mantar, was shown his viral videos and questioned by multiple police teams during his remand, officials said on Sunday. Bhardwaj (22) was asked more than 100 questions during his remand, a police source said, adding that while he answered some of those, he did not respond to several others. According to sources, investigators showed Bhardwaj several of his viral videos as part of the questioning and confronted him with the statements and claims made by him in the videos. The sources said Bhardwaj showed no sign of remorse during his questioning. Bhardwaj was arrested on Friday after being detained in Uttar Pradesh's Bulandshahr and sent to a daylong police custody by a Delhi court on Saturday. He was produced before Additional Sessions Judge Saurabh Pratap Singh Laler at his residence around 2 pm, while his legal-aid counsel appeared before the judge through video-conferencing. The development came a day after the Delhi Police added sections of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act and the charge of criminal intimidation to the FIR registered over the alleged assault. A fresh FIR under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act was also lodged on a complaint from the minor activist, who alleged that she was subjected to online threats and harassment after speaking out against the assault on her father. The police action followed outrage over a video podcast, in which Bhardwaj allegedly claimed that he had "cracked the skull" of the minor activist's father during the protest. He had subsequently claimed that he had acted in self-defence. The Delhi Police had earlier said the injuries suffered by the student activist's father were "simple in nature". Investigators are also going through Bhardwaj's social-media posts, videos and other digital material as part of the probe, the officials said.



ISRO says it will not be privatised nor its importance will be diminished

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) on Sunday issued a clarification, saying that neither it would be privatised nor would its importance be diminished. In a post on X, the space agency asserted that participation of the private sector enables ISRO to focus strongly on the next generation of India's space programme, while the industry scales mature technologies and capabilities.



The development came after nine employee associations at ISRO wrote to the space agency's Chairperson V Narayanan on September 4, seeking official clarification on the proposed transfer of its manufacturing and operational functions to private entities. They were referring to the remarks

made by Pawan Goenka, chairperson of the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACe), on August 21. ISRO said in the post that its "role will progressively strengthen in areas where its scientific expertise matters most: frontier R&D, advanced technologies, human space flight, next-generation launch systems, deep-space and planetary missions and strategic national capabilities." The space agency added that it would continue developing cutting-edge technologies, including advanced payloads for communication, navigation and Earth observation, sensors, propulsion systems and other critical technologies. "Meanwhile, mature and routinely manufactured systems can increasingly be scaled through industry. Production of mature launch vehicles, routine satellites and other established systems can increasingly be undertaken by industry or PSUs through appropriate competitive processes," said ISRO.



BRS president K Chandrasekhar Rao

The Palamuru-Ranga Reddy Lift Irrigation Scheme aims to irrigate 12.3 lakh acres using

Youth power to make Haryana drug-free: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Chandigarh

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday declared that the youth of the State have resolved to fight a decisive battle against drug abuse, adding that their enthusiasm would give a new direction to the campaign to make Haryana completely drug-free. Addressing a massive gathering as the Chief Guest at a half marathon organised in Rewari under the theme 'Nashe se jung, Rewari ke sang', the Chief Minister emphasised that the state Government has instituted a four-tier framework focusing on enforcement, awareness, treatment, and rehabilitation to tackle substance abuse. The marathon was aimed at taking the resolve of 'Nasha Mukta Haryana-Khel Yukt Haryana' to every corner of society and steering the youth towards sports. "There can be no place for a social



Haryana-Khel Yukt Haryana' to every corner of society and steering the youth towards sports.

Chhattisgarh's mining reforms: From digital governance to critical minerals and tribal livelihoods

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Raipur

The Chhattisgarh Minor Mineral Ordinary Sand (Excavation and Business) Rules, 2025 have marked a significant reform in the regulation and management of ordinary sand in the State, with an emphasis on transparency, streamlined administration and better control over excavation and trade. A major change under the new framework is the introduction of electronic auction through a reverse-auction mechanism for allotment of sand quarry leases, replacing the earlier system and bringing the allocation process onto a more transparent and competitive platform. The Rules also seek to strengthen regulation of sand excavation, transportation and trade, while ensuring compliance with environmental and other statutory requirements. The new framework is already being

implemented through district-level electronic reverse auctions for sand quarry leases. The amendment permits Fixed Deposit Receipt (FDR) as an alternative for Bank Guarantee and extends certain compliance timelines from 60 days to one year, providing greater operational flexibility to the leasee. The amendments strengthen the regulatory framework for sand mining by introducing provisions for lapse of non-operational leases, reservation of sand quarries for Government PSUs, and stricter enforcement measures. They empower the Collector to confiscate performance security for violations and provide for show-cause proceedings and lease cancellation for specified non-compliances. Overall, the changes aim to promote effective resource utilisation, stronger regulatory oversight, and improved environmental governance.

The e-Ret Sangwari Portal is intended to provide royalty-free sand to eligible beneficiaries of Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana through an online process, linking mineral-resource management with the State's rural housing programme. The initiative is expected to ease the supply of sand for construction activities and help ensure the timely completion of housing projects. Further, Khanij Online 2.0 is a unified digital platform designed to streamline mineral administration through automated workflows, real-time monitoring, and integrated enforcement mechanisms. The platform digitises concession management, permit issuance, QR-code-based e-Transit Pass generation, dispatch tracking, compliance reporting, and revenue reconciliation within a single governance framework. The portal strengthens the implementation of the



Chhattisgarh District Mineral Foundation Trust Rules, 2015. Under the amended framework, areas within 15 km of mining operations are classified as directly affected, while areas within 25 km are classified as indirectly affected. The Key features of Portal 2.0 include stakeholder-spe-

cific dashboards and comprehensive MIS reports, mandatory digital signatures for fund demands submitted by implementing agencies, auto-

mated capping of fund releases based on sanctioned budgets; fund demands linked to the submission of work-progress documents and photographs and mobile-based monitoring with geo-tagged images, amongst others. The Directorate of Geology and Mining, Chhattisgarh, has so far successfully auctioned 65 mineral blocks, comprising 49 bulk mineral blocks, 13 critical and strategic mineral blocks, and 3 deep-seated mineral blocks. These auctions are expected to generate approximately ₹4.35 lakh crore in revenue over the life of the mines, reflecting the scale and long-term economic potential of mineral development in the State. Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai launched the TIN (Tribal Incentives on Natural Resources) Portal, a digital platform aimed at bringing greater transparency and efficiency to the pro-

curement and sale of tin ore collected by tribal communities in the Bastar region. Developed by the Chhattisgarh Mineral Development Corporation (CMDC) in collaboration with Indian Overseas Bank, the portal digitises the entire value chain from beneficiary registration and ore collection to procurement, transportation, sale, price determination and payment. The initiative introduces QR-based verification, digital identities, online stock tracking, real-time monitoring and SMS alerts, while enabling Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) of sale proceeds to beneficiaries' bank accounts. The State has also released an amended edition of the Chhattisgarh Minor Mineral Rules, 2015, updated as of August 6, 2026, strengthening the regulatory framework for minor minerals while emphasising community participation and environmental safeguards.



■ States Focus ■



HIGHER EDUCATION MUST SERVE DEMOCRACY AND SOCIETY: VP

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Sunday said higher educational institutions must prepare students to make meaningful contributions to society and democracy, rather than merely equip them for careers. Addressing the golden jubilee celebrations of Geetanagar College in Guwahati, Radhakrishnan underlined the role of these institutions in nation-building and promoting inclusive growth. He also inaugurated the new academic building of the college, which was formerly known as Kanya Mahavidyalaya, through the virtual mode on the occasion. In his maiden visit to Assam after becoming vice president, Radhakrishnan said educational institutions were among the most important vehicles for building a developed India, as they can create the workforce required to realise the vision. (PTI)



11% OF VOTERS' NAMES DELETED FROM SIKKIM ELECTORAL ROLLS

A total of 52,551 electors were deleted from Sikkim's electoral roll during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), reducing the number of voters by around 11.16 per cent, a statement said on Sunday. The final roll has 4,18,467 eligible voters, compared with 4,71,018 in the pre-SIR voters' list, the Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO) office said in a statement. The draft electoral roll released in July had 4,33,294 electors, of whom 3,61,159 or 83.35 per cent were successfully mapped with their own or parents' electoral details from the previous qualifying roll or the last SIR. The remaining 72,135 electors (16.65 per cent) could not be mapped, it said. (PTI)

Siddaramaiah demands 75% quota for Dalits, BCs, minorities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Sunday called for implementation of the Caste Census and increase of reservation for Dalits, Backward Communities (BCs) and minorities to 75 per cent, saying an egalitarian society could not be achieved without equal opportunities based on population.

Speaking at the Karnataka State Backward Castes Federation's Silver Jubilee celebration, Siddaramaiah said the caste survey report must be implemented and asserted that reservation should be provided according to the population of each community.

"If all of you are to get social justice, there must be at least 75 per cent reservation. Dalits, backward communities and minorities — all of them must get 75 per cent," he said.

Only when everyone gets reservation according to their



Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah

caste and according to their population will it be possible to create an egalitarian society, he said, adding that similar reservation based on caste and population in the Lok Sabha and Legislative Assembly is necessary to achieve political equality.

Siddaramaiah said the caste survey conducted during his earlier tenure as chief minister should be implemented.

He was referring to the report submitted by the Backward Classes

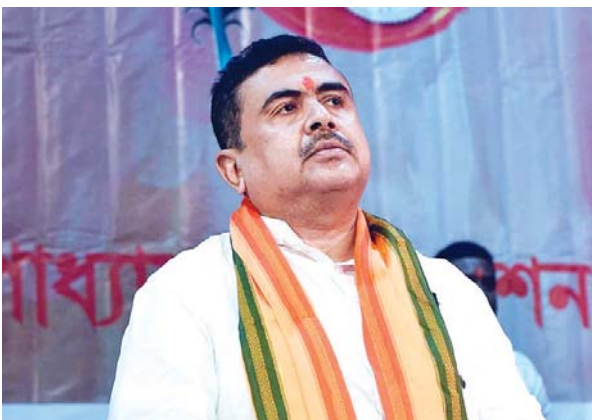
Saved West Bengal from being greater Bangladesh: Suvendu

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari has claimed that his Government has prevented the State from becoming a "greater Bangladesh" by thwarting an 'active plot' to change the demography of the region.

Iterating that Bengal was not the same as what it used to be even a few months ago, when the Trinamool Congress ruled the State, the Chief Minister said that there was a time when "people had to move the High Court to organise a Durga Puja or an event of Ram Navami.

"But now the people are free to organise their religious programmes" and recite Hanuman Chalisa openly, he said, claiming, earlier "active plots were being made to change the demography of the State...



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari

But it has been successfully thwarted." He said, "the new awakening that has come to Bengal has to be preserved... It is your duty to preserve this new awakening... We all have to protect Bengal from turning into greater Bangladesh," adding, "no one should be able to divide us in the name of lan-

guage, caste etc... We must remain united."

Ever since he came to power, the Adhikari had been following the "detect, delete and deport" formula insofar as transborder illegal immigration was concerned. "You may have noticed how thousands of illegal immigrants queued up every day

at the border to return to their country," he said, reminding how they had been sheltered by the previous Trinamool Congress Government to further its vote bank politics.

Adhikari, who was speaking at a programme to celebrate Janmashtami, had, immediately after coming to power, allotted the requisite amount of land demanded by the Border Security Force to put up barbed fencing. Bengal shares more than 2,000 km of international border with the neighbouring Bangladesh.

In a separate programme, the Chief Minister also disclosed his plans to construct at least two 'CM Shri' schools in each of the 23 districts of the State to facilitate modern education. The schools would be modelled after the central schools, he said, adding that existing schools too would be upgraded.

Jantar Mantar student stir, mass struggles could impact Assembly polls, says CPI(M)

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CPI(M) said on Sunday that the Jantar Mantar student movement and other mass struggles could have a "very significant impact" on the coming Assembly elections.

The party asserted that the protests had helped break an atmosphere of fear among the youth towards the Narendra Modi Government, the RSS and its leadership. CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby, addressing a press conference after the party's Politburo meeting, said the impact of the Jantar



CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby

Mantar struggle could already be felt in the BJP's defeat in Bihar's Bankipur by-election and expressed hope that it would influence the upcoming State polls.

"At Jantar Mantar, our youth have demonstrated

that they don't fear Narendra Modi, Amit Shah or the RSS. There was a general atmosphere of fear, which the protest removed," Baby said. Drawing a parallel with the Samyukt Kisan Morcha-led farmers' agitation, he said people's movements can influence electoral outcomes, particularly in areas where such struggles are strong.

"Earlier we had the Samyukt Kisan Morcha struggle; after that the Lok Sabha elections happened, and that impacted the particular belt where the agitation was powerful, and BJP lost many seats," he said.

"People's struggles — workers, peasants, youth, women, Adivasis, Dalits, minorities — if they come forward and agitate, it will impact on the minds of people in the big cities," he said.

Baby said the CPI(M)'s approach in the coming elections would be to use whatever influence it has to defeat the BJP and its allies. Regarding seat-sharing and contesting seats, he said the party would discuss the issue with political parties in individual States and assess which candidate had the best chance of defeating the BJP in each constituency.

Rajnath to visit Sri Lanka to expand bilateral defence ties

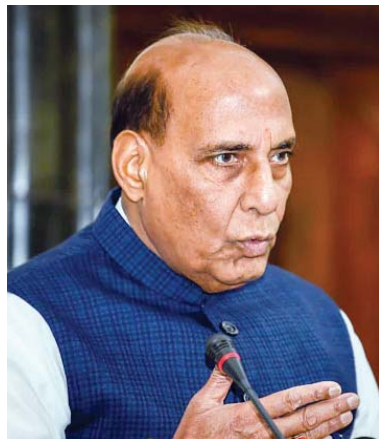
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Sri Lanka will review the entire gamut of their bilateral defence ties and explore ways to expand them during Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's three-day visit there starting September 8.

Giving details about his schedule, the defence ministry said in New Delhi on Sunday that Rajnath Singh will hold consultations with the leadership of Sri Lanka on a range of issues and interact with the Indian diaspora in Colombo. He will lead a high-level delegation comprising senior officials from the Ministry of Defence and the Ministry of External Affairs.

India and Sri Lanka share deep civilisational ties and a multifaceted partnership, anchored by regional security, defence, economic and trade cooperation and strong people-to-people ties.

The bilateral relationship received further impetus when India assisted Sri Lanka during the economic crisis and provided assistance, as one of the first responders, in the aftermath of Cyclone Dittwah in Sri Lanka in 2025.



It underscored India's continued commitment and emphasis on the 'Neighbourhood First' policy and Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions). The defence minister's visit will further strengthen the traditionally strong and friendly bilateral relations in mutually beneficial areas, including a strong maritime and defence partnership, the ministry said.

IAF's Sarang team arrives in Egypt for El Alamein airshow

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Sarang Helicopter Display Team of the Indian Air Force has reached Egypt to participate in the second edition of the El Alamein International Airshow, scheduled to be held from September 8 to 10 at El Alamein International Airport, the defence ministry said in New Delhi on Sunday.

The IAF Sarang team is the world's only five-helicopter display team. The team will showcase precision, professionalism and flying skills through a series of meticulously choreographed displays. This marks another significant milestone in international engagements by the Indian Air Force reflecting growing defence and diplomatic ties between India and Egypt.

Flying the indigenously designed and manufactured Advanced Light Helicopter (ALH) Dhruv, the Sarang team is renowned for its demanding formation manoeuvres, close-proximity flying and synchronised aerial sequences. The display highlights not only the exceptional skill and discipline of its pilots but also the capabilities of India's indigenous aerospace industry.

Ex-TMC MLA Kabir summoned over Abhishek Banerjee office row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Kolkata Police on Sunday sent a notice to former IPS officer and the TMC's ex-MLA Humayun Kabir, asking him to appear before officers investigating the alleged scuffle during the removal of an "illegal" billboard at a building housing party MP Abhishek Banerjee's office, an official said.

The former legislator has been asked to appear at Shakespeare Sarani police station on Wednesday noon.

Authorities on August 27 removed an "illegal" billboard of the TMC from the top of a building in central Kolkata's Camac Street, during which private guards at Banerjee's office, his supporters and some party leaders had scuffled with police and Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC) officials. Three FIRs were registered at the Shakespeare Sarani police station. Banerjee has been named as an accused in two of the FIRs,



TMC's ex-MLA Humayun Kabir

while Rajya Sabha MP Derek O'Brien, former MLA Kabir and former councillor Baishwanar Chatterjee are among others named in the cases, police officials said.

Police have already questioned Banerjee, his personal assistant Sumit Ray, O'Brien and Chatterjee in connection with the case.

On Sunday, a team of police personnel from the Shakespeare Sarani Police Station visited Kabir's residence in the Kasba area of southern Kolkata to serve the notice, which he received, the official added. Sources

said Kabir told the team that he wanted to appear before the police on Monday and that he could reach the police station at 1:30 pm.

The police had earlier visited Kabir's residence twice to serve him notices in connection with the case; the former MLA was not present there then. Referring to the August 27 incident, Kabir said, "They (municipal officials and police) had come to demolish the office. But no rules were followed. There was no proper notice. It was a piece of paper without a memo number.

Arunachal Police crack trafficking case, rescue 38

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

Arunachal Pradesh Police have rescued 38 people, including 34 children, from various locations and arrested four persons who were allegedly involved in human trafficking, officials said on Sunday.

The children were rescued from Aalo, Mechuka, Pasighat, Naharlagun, Itanagar and Longding area of Arunachal Pradesh and from Assam, they said.

A trafficking case was registered at Namsai Police Station last month. It is being investigated by Namsai Deputy Superintendent of Police Kengo Dirchi under the supervision of Superintendent of Police Sangey Thinley, in close coordination with the Child Welfare Committee (CWC) and the District Child Protection Unit (DCPU), Namsai. In a press statement, Thinley said police have



arrested four facilitators so far, with the latest arrest being identified as Rupali Padung. Her alleged role in the transportation and illegal placement of the victims is currently under legal scrutiny.

Officials said the probe aims to unearth the complete trafficking network, financial transactions, electronic evidence, and secondary links.

Parents, guardians, and individuals where the victims were allegedly placed are also being thoroughly examined, with appropriate legal action to follow based on evidence.

D Raja questions PM Modi over fall in education Budget

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

CPI general secretary D Raja on Sunday hit out at Prime Minister Narendra Modi for making political attacks during his Teachers' Day address at Delhi University's Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC), and asked him to explain the change in the Union Government's education Budget during his tenure.

Raja's remarks came a day after Modi, addressing the SRCC's centenary celebrations on Teachers' Day, revived his "dimagi naxal" remark and accused critics of being unable to digest India's 7.8 per cent economic growth.

Modi also contrasted the country's economic situation in 2013 with its current position, saying India had moved from the "Fragile Five" to being the fastest-growing major economy.

In a post on X, Raja said



CPI general secretary D Raja

that instead of addressing the "real concerns" of teachers and students, the prime minister had chosen to make political attacks.

"He should understand that this will not work. People are no longer willing to believe his claims because of the Government's monumental failures," Raja said.

The CPI leader alleged that the Government had even gone to the extent of "manipulating and misrepresenting economic data" and was now branding those who

questioned its claims as "dimagi naxals".

"But the country will continue to question. Dissent cannot be criminalised, and questions cannot be silenced by name-calling," Raja said. He asked the prime minister to answer what he described as a simple question: "By what percentage has the Union Government's education budget fallen during your tenure?" "Instead of attacking critics, answer the teachers and students of India," he said.



Rahul slams PM over police action on students in Bihar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday lashed out at Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary over the police action against protesting students in Bihar, asking that while their broken bones would be fixed, their shattered dreams could be restored.

Gandhi shared a video of his recent meeting with students and youngsters from Bihar who, he said, endured "horrific police brutality" for raising their voices against alleged irregularities in the examination system.

In his post in Hindi accompanying the video, Gandhi said, "Imagine, what sin had these children committed that they were shot with bullets? They had only asked the Government for three things — education, employment, and accountability."

"The bone in one student's leg was broken by an AK-47 bullet. His dream of joining the army and serving the nation vanished along with it. Bullets tore through the shoulders of two other students," the leader of the opposition



in the Lok Sabha said.

Asserting that the students are not criminals, he said they were the children from poor families who had stepped out to study, carrying their families' dreams. "Some wanted a good job, some wanted to change their family's circumstances," he said.

"The bullet wounds will heal, but where is the hospital that treats the fear that has now settled deep inside these children?" Gandhi questioned.

"Prime Minister ji, Chief Minister ji, their broken bones would be fixed. Can you restore their shattered

dreams?" he said.

Gandhi, on meeting students from Bihar on Thursday, had said the BJP should remember that any regime that suppresses the voice of youngsters eventually has to answer to the people, and claimed that day is not far off.

"Police lathis as well as gunfire from AK-47 and pistols left many students injured. A young man aspiring to serve the country in the Army had his leg battered by an AK-47 bullet — and with it, his life-long dream was also shattered," Gandhi had said in a post in Hindi on X.

These young people were

merely demanding fair opportunities, a transparent examination system and their rights, he added.

What was the need to use lathis and bullets in response to such demands, the Congress leader had asked.

"The Government cannot absolve itself of responsibility for such extreme brutality by merely blaming a few low-ranking officials. This action is either the result of orders from above or a sign of the administration's utter failure," he had said.

"No matter what the Bihar Government does, I stand with these young people. I am ready to provide them with every possible assistance," Gandhi had said.

Patna witnessed a pitched battle between job aspirants and police last month as demonstrators tried to march to the chief minister's residence demanding a single-tier teacher job exam and a transparent recruitment process.

The students' protest in Bihar, which began in the first week of August, has received support from opposition leaders, including RJD's working president Tejashwi Yadav.

Bihar floods affect 19 lakh, Ganga rises in Patna

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Over 19 lakh people across 11 districts of Bihar have been affected by floods, with authorities sounding an alert in downstream areas after the water level of the Ganga crossed a crucial flood mark at Gandhi Ghat in Patna, officials said on Sunday.

Hathidah and subsequent gauge stations in the state capital are likely to be impacted over the next one to three days, as the Ganga's water level topped the 'highest flood level' (HFL) at Gandhi Ghat in Patna following heavy rain, they said.

Due to the rise in water levels of various rivers in the state, around 19.57 lakh people in 330 gram panchayats across 11 districts — Patna, Bhojpur, Saran, Vaishali, Bhagalpur, Begusarai, Buxar, Samastipur, Munger, Katihar and Araria — have been affected, the officials said.

According to the latest advisory issued by the Water Resources Department (WRD), the level of the Ganga at Hathidah may also cross its previous HFL, prompting heightened vigilance in Begusarai, Lakhisarai, Munger, Bhagalpur and Katihar districts, they said.

"Officials and field-level authorities have been directed to remain alert and con-



tinuously monitor water levels, embankments, vulnerable locations and low-lying areas, while taking precautionary measures as required. "Engineers have been asked to keep flood-control resources and machinery ready. People in affected areas have been advised to avoid going near the river and remain cautious," the advisory stated.

The local administration has also been asked to monitor boat operations, prevent overloading and keep residents informed about the situation.

"At Gandhi Ghat in Patna, the Ganga was flowing at 50.57 metres at 6 am on Sunday, which is 0.05 metre above its previous HFL of 50.52 metres, recorded on August 21, 2016. The trend is stable. "At Pandarak in Patna, the Ganga was flowing at 43.92 metres at 6 am, which is 0.19 metre above its previous HFL of 43.73 metres,

recorded on August 16, 2021," the advisory said.

The rivers that are flowing above the danger level in the state include the Gandak at Dumariaghat and Hajipur, the Kosi at Baltara and Kursela, the Budhi Gandak at Khagaria, the Ganga at Hathidah, Bhagalpur, Kahalgaon, Buxar and Munger, the Punpun at Sripalpur, the Bagmati at Benibad and the Ghaghra at Darauli, the officials said.

A total of 110 community kitchens are currently operating in various districts for the flood-affected people, they said, adding, to facilitate the evacuation of people and movement in the affected areas, 1,345 boats have been pressed into service.

Besides, 27 teams of the SDRF and 10 from the NDRF have been deployed in various districts.

In a notification, the East Central Railway on Sunday said some trains have been

cancelled or diverted because of the "alarmingly high water level at bridge number 21" that connects Punpun and Parsa Bazar stations on the Patna-Gaya section. Meanwhile, the opposition sought 'national disaster' status in Bihar in the wake of the floods.

Claiming that 76 per cent of the state's area has been affected by floods, RJD national working president Tejashwi Yadav said 19 districts were reeling under the deluge, with more than 20 lakh people affected.

Yadav, who is Leader of the Opposition in the assembly, said in a post on X, "Livestock has been swept away... public infrastructure severely damaged and lives and property worth thousands of crores lost in the floods." He accused the Bihar Government of being "indifferent" towards the flood victims, and urged the Centre to immediately declare the situation a "national disaster" and provide special financial assistance to the state.

Yadav also sought the deployment of Air Force helicopters for rescue operations, and requested Prime Minister Narendra Modi to visit Bihar, assess the situation on the ground and announce relief measures.

Floating screens on Dal Lake to mark first J&K film fest

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Srinagar

Iconic Bollywood films shot in the Valley, *Kashmir Ki Kali*, *Kabhi Kabhie*, *Arzoo* and *Junglee*, will be screened on floating screens installed on Dal Lake starting Monday as part of the first International Film Festival of Jammu and Kashmir (IFFJK).

The four-day festival, themed "Rang-e-Cinema," runs from September 7 to 10 and will feature 135 films from more than 40 countries.

Organisers say the floating cinema will give the event a distinctive visual and experiential character, with audiences watching from shikaras against the lake and the Zabarwan hills.

Director Information and Public Relations, J&K, Shreya Singhal said the initiative is expected to provide an iconic setting for screenings while



Lail Chawk

FILE PHOTO

showcasing the unique cultural and natural landscape of Jammu and Kashmir to visiting filmmakers, artists and delegates from across India and abroad. She added that the festival seeks to revive J&K's cinematic legacy and position the Union Territory

as a destination for filmmaking and cultural exchange.

Main venues include SKICC and INOX in Srinagar, with additional programmes in Jammu and a dedicated day in Gulmarg.

The festival received

around 1,100 submissions from dozens of countries before a preview committee shortlisted the final 135 titles. Categories include International Panorama, Bharat Panorama, Cinema of the World, Documentary, Hybrid Documentary and

J&K Select. A prize purse of ₹96 lakh will be distributed across nine award categories. The opening screening at INOX Srinagar is the Lebanese film *Dead Dog*, directed by Sarah Francis. Masterclasses, workshops, panel discussions and cultural performances will run alongside the films, giving local students and emerging filmmakers a chance to interact with industry professionals.

More than 300 delegates are expected. Officials say IFFJK aims to rebuild that connection, promote film tourism and create economic opportunities in the creative sector. Preparations have included beautification and sanitation drives around Dal Lake and key routes, along with security and hospitality arrangements for visiting guests.

Union Ministers, Governor, Chief Minister, Lieutenant Governors, Tourism Secretaries of different States/UTs and many Bollywood personalities are scheduled to attend the first International Film Festival in Srinagar.

A five-member international jury comprising distinguished personalities from the world of cinema, including internationally acclaimed filmmakers, cinematographers, sound artists and film curators, will evaluate the entries.

The jury, headed by acclaimed cinematographer-director Santosh Sivan, includes Oscar- and BAFTA-winning sound designer Resul Pookutty, German film curator Dorothee Wenner, media entrepreneur Keiko Bang and National Award-winning filmmaker Himansu Sekhar Khatua.

Maharashtra ministers call for DJ-free Ganesh festival

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar

Maharashtra Minister of State for Health Meghana Bordikar and district Guardian Minister Sanjay Shirsat on Sunday made a strong pitch against the use of DJ sound systems during festivals.

Speaking to reporters, Bordikar emphasised that while festivals should be celebrated with enthusiasm, they must not cause distress or health hazards to others.

"Unfortunately, my cousin died because of a DJ system last year. We repeatedly appeal to people, and the Supreme Court has also laid down guidelines, but many fail to adhere to them. The use of DJs can lead to fatal consequences, and I have experienced this personal tragedy myself," she said.

Echoing her concerns, Shirsat said that the city administration and police will strictly enforce noise regulations, urging organis-

ers to celebrate with traditional music instead of DJs.

The MLA, who chaired a preparatory meeting for the upcoming Ganesh festival, noted that public opinion on the issue is divided, but the administration must prioritise public health.

"As far as our city is concerned, we do not want DJ systems. The police will take strict action as per the law - offenders will be fined, and their vehicles carrying the equipment will be seized,"



he warned. He urged Ganesh mandals to voluntarily refrain from using high-decibel sound systems to avoid action.

"I appeal to people to celebrate with enthusiasm and in a traditional manner. Small children and the elderly should be able to comfortably participate and understand the cultural essence of the Ganesh festival. I believe the mandals will heed our appeal," Shirsat added.

TVK functionary hacked to death in Chennai; five arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

A functionary of the ruling TVK was hacked to death by an armed gang in Besant Nagar in Chennai, police said on Sunday, with the murder drawing criticism from the Opposition over the State's law and order situation.

Police have arrested at least five persons in connection with the murder so far, officials said. The deceased, identified as Kannan, was chased and attacked with machetes on Saturday night, police said. According to police, Kannan was a history-sheeter with a criminal record. CCTV footage of the attack has since surfaced and been widely shared. Preliminary investigation suggested previous enmity as the likely motive, pointing to a revenge killing, police sources said. The murder drew immediate political criticism, with Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin targeting the Government and alleging that the TVK was a "dumping ground where criminals seek refuge". Taking



a swipe at the administration, the DMK leader said a history-sheeter who had joined the ruling TVK was chased and hacked to death on an open road, and questioned whether this was the "Vetri" law and order the Government claimed to have established in Tamil Nadu. The incident came a day before Chief Minister and TVK founder C Joseph Vijay is scheduled to respond to the Opposition's criticism of the law and order situation in the Tamil Nadu Assembly.

"Ahead of the Hon'ble Chief Minister replying to the debate on the Police Demand

for Grants tomorrow, a functionary of his own party has been murdered in the Capital," Udhayanidhi said in a post on X.

Joining the Opposition's criticism, PMK president Dr Anbumani Ramadoss cited the murder along with three ATM heists in the suburbs over the past fortnight to target the Government's handling of security. Ramadoss said the killing of Kannan had triggered fear among the public and alleged that no effective measures were in place to curb violent crime and robberies in the Chennai metropolitan area.

VHP's Garba diktat unconstitutional: NCP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The NCP(SP) on Sunday slammed the Vishva Hindu Parishad's (VHP) call to bar Muslims from participating in Garba events during Navratri, terming it "unconstitutional", and questioned the BJP-led Maharashtra Government's silence on the issue.

The VHP has announced that Muslims would not be allowed entry to 'Garba' and 'Dandiya' venues across the state during the upcoming Navratri festival, and issued "guidelines" for organisers to verify par-

ticipants' identities by checking their Aadhaar cards and applying 'tilak' on their foreheads.

The Navratri festival will begin on October 11.

Terming the VHP's decision as unconstitutional, NCP (SP) national spokesperson Clyde Crasto said, "We live in a society where we have co-existed in peace and harmony. This diktat from the VHP is bound to disturb it." Crasto, in a statement, questioned if the state Government would remain "mute" and allow the right-wing organisation to dictate law and order in Maharashtra.



NCP(SP) national spokesperson Clyde Crasto

London-bound flight makes emergency landing in Bengaluru



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

A London-bound Virgin Atlantic flight carrying 270 passengers was forced to make an "emergency landing" at the Kempegowda International Airport here on Sunday after developing a technical glitch shortly after take-off, sources at Bangalore International Airport Limited (BIAL), which operates KIAB, said.

The flight took off from KIAB at around 8:20 am but reportedly developed a technical issue soon after departure, prompting the crew to

circle the aircraft near Tumakuru for more than half an hour before returning to Bengaluru.

All passengers on board are safe, sources at BIAL said, adding that the aircraft was brought back to KIAB as a safety precaution and made an emergency landing.

The exact nature of the technical problem was not immediately known. Authorities are looking into the cause of the incident.

A spokesperson for Virgin Atlantic said the VS317 flight from Bengaluru to London Heathrow returned to

Bengaluru shortly after departure due to a technical issue. "The aircraft landed safely as a precaution, and the flight was subsequently cancelled," he said in a statement. The airline said the safety and security of its customers and crew are always its top priority.

"We sincerely apologise for the inconvenience caused to our customers. Our teams are supporting those affected and are working hard to rebook them onto alternative services as quickly as possible," the company said.



Editor's
TAKE

Belgium hedges against an unpredictable US

From defence co-production to the India-EU free trade agreement, Brussels and New Delhi are finding common ground for a rules-based economic order

When Bart De Wever landed in New Delhi on September 2, he became the first Belgian Prime Minister to visit India in two decades – his first as PM. A wreath at Rajghat, warm words at Hyderabad House and ten outcomes in three days signalled more than protocol: a considered European wager on India just as Washington's commitment to open trade looks conditional at best. De Wever did not need to name Donald Trump in Mumbai to be understood. Addressing the India-Belgium High-Level Dialogue on the India-EU Free Trade Agreement, he cautioned against a rising tide of protectionism, mocking leaders who "decide something on Monday, revoke it on Wednesday, and reinstall it on Saturday." When the room applauded, he added, wryly, that their applause told him exactly who he meant. India needed no footnote. Its exporters had lived that whiplash directly: a 50 per cent US tariff over Russian oil purchases, cut to 18 per cent by a bilateral deal, then to 10 per cent after the Supreme Court struck down Trump's wider tariff powers.

For his hosts, De Wever's complaint simply described the recent past. Belgium brought substance to match the sentiment. Officials framed the outcomes around "three Ts" – trade, technology, talent. A defence Letter of Intent, an industry MoU between Belgium's BDSI and India's SIDM, and contracts signed by defence ministers Rajnath Singh and Theo Francken point toward co-designing and co-producing military hardware, not merely buying it.

A CBI-Belgian Federal Police pact on transnational crime carries an unspoken subtext: the pending extradition of fugitive diamantaire Mehl Choksi, in Belgian custody since 2025. Add semiconductors, critical minerals, renewable energy, an investment fast-track mechanism, and a target to double the \$13-billion trade relationship within five years, and this reads less like a courtesy call than a partnership being deliberately rebuilt. The deeper convergence, though, is of worldview. Belgium and India – one a small federal state balancing linguistic communities, the other the world's largest democracy – share a commitment to pluralism, the rule of law and open markets that both leaders called a "natural" fit.

Brussels backs India's bid for a permanent UN Security Council seat, and De Wever went out of his way to praise Modi personally, casting him as a rare point of steadiness amid global disorder. Beneath the flattery sits calculation: as Washington's tariffs swing and Beijing's leverage grows, both capitals are hedging toward each other, and toward a rules-based order that no single power controls. That same logic underwrites the India-EU Free Trade Agreement itself – concluded in January, awaiting signature, and set to scrap tariffs on 96 per cent of EU goods, the largest such pact either side has struck. The takeaway is straightforward. Europe's middle powers, modest individually, are becoming collectively significant as India diversifies away from an unpredictable Washington. Whether this visit's promise holds will be measured less in joint statements than in whether its MoUs mature into contracts – and whether Choksi finally comes home.

Teachers: The artists of education

In an age when machines are becoming capable of almost everything predictable, the irreplaceable act remains the human one: a teacher who sees potential in a student that the student cannot yet see in themselves



JAYANT CHAUDHARY

No one remembers the exact day they learned to read. But almost everyone remembers the teacher who taught them. That asymmetry, between the forgettable moment and the unforgettable person, tells us something essential about teaching. A teacher leaves behind something that cannot be easily measured: the confidence to try, the discipline to persist, the curiosity to ask, or sometimes simply the belief that one is capable of more. Thus, teaching cannot be classified as anything less than an art.

The National Awards to Teachers, conferred each year by the Hon'ble President of India, honour a chosen few whose contribution has risen above the rest. Nonetheless, in every corner of the country, in classrooms, skill labs, polytechnics, sports grounds, and music rooms, students find their own way to say thank you. A handwritten note. A moment of recognition in a morning assembly. A quiet acknowledgement that stays with a teacher long after the day is over. These are not lesser celebrations but, in many ways, the truest ones.

The data, however, tells us a parallel concerning story. OECD's 2026 Teacher Knowledge Survey distinguishes between knowing a subject and the ability to teach it. Its findings posit that subject knowledge does not always translate into effective pedagogy. The point is simple but important: knowing something deeply and knowing how to help another person learn it are not the same skill. Teaching is an art, requiring an understanding of human connections, pedagogy and some theatrics for the classroom.

The UNESCO Global Report on Teachers, 2024, places a hard number on what neglecting this profession costs. The world needs 44 million additional primary and secondary teachers by 2030, and over half are needed simply to replace those already leaving. Meanwhile, the McKinsey Global Institute estimates that between 75 million and 375 million workers globally will need to switch occupational categories by 2030 due to automation. In such a scenario, the value of competent teachers is more than ever.

India has acknowledged this challenge and is responding with intent. The four-year Integrated Teacher Education Program, launched in consonance with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, integrates subject mastery and pedagogy into a single under-



THE HON'BLE PRIME MINISTER MEETS EVERY YEAR WITH NATIONAL AWARD WINNERS NOT MERELY TO CONGRATULATE BUT TO LISTEN, TO KNOW THEIR STORIES FROM THE GROUND, AND TO OFFER THE PERSPECTIVE THAT ONLY LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE CAN PROVIDE. TEACHING IS A CREATIVE ACT, AND CROSS-LEARNING ACROSS FIELDS HELPS RENEW THIS CREATIVITY

The writer is Union Minister of State, Ministry of Education & Ministry of Skill Development & Entrepreneurship

graduate degree, attracting the best minds into teaching by design.

To ensure congruent standards amongst the in-service teachers, the National Professional Standards for Teachers (NPST) tie career advancement to demonstrated teaching quality rather than mere seniority. To benefit from cross-sectoral learning, the National Mission for Mentoring (NMM) provides structured support to teachers to learn from mentors from various fields. I, too, have registered as a mentor for this mission. The Hon'ble Prime Minister meets every year with National Award winners not merely to congratulate but to listen, to know their stories from the ground, and to offer the perspective that only leadership experience can provide. Teaching is a creative act, and cross-learning across fields helps renew this creativity.

India is also expanding who counts as a teacher, and that is perhaps the most novel idea of all. Understanding of Lifelong Learning for All in Society (ULLAS), the New India Literacy Program, is built on the principle that anyone who is literate can teach someone who is not.

As we celebrate International Literacy Day this year, nine states and union territories have been declared fully literate under this program. This spirit is further embodied in the Vidyanjali portal of the Ministry of Education. It connects over 8.75 lakh government schools to volunteers who bring their expertise, whether in dance, mathematics, public speaking, or craft, into classrooms as a gift.

Every one of them acts as a teacher. Every subject they bring is valued equally. Because at its core, teaching is not a technical func-

tion but a craft. Every lesson plan is a composition. Every explanation is a performance.

An artform does not distinguish between the artists and thus any hierarchy that we carry in our heads must be examined and dismantled. Sometimes, the music teacher or the PE teacher is considered supplementary and the vocational trainer, a fallback. This classification is not just unfair but completely wrong. When examination pressure mounts, music or exercise may restore calm, which aids preparation.

With India's growing orange economy, multiple art forms shall prepare students for one of the fastest-growing sectors of the modern world. As sports universities take shape and supplement national athletic infrastructure, the sports coach and PE teacher will open gateways to authentic career pathways. The ITI trainer teaching precision manufacturing is crafting skills that help construct bridges and strengthen hospitals. That is nation-building in another form.

In an age when machines are becoming capable of almost everything predictable, the irreplaceable act remains the human one: a teacher who sees potential in a student that the student cannot yet see in themselves. That act has no algorithm. It does not stop when the school bell rings. And it belongs to every teacher, in every subject, in every kind of institution across this country.

The Latin phrase sums it up aptly: Non scholae sed vitae discimus. We learn not for school, but for life. And the teacher, the true artist of human possibility, is the person who makes that possible.

PIC TALK



Children shower flowers on a statue of Mother Mary as part of preparations for the Monthi Fest at a church, in Mangaluru, Karnataka

PHOTO: PTI

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

Empty Mind to Receive the New

We take pride in what we know. Years of experience, qualifications, hard earned opinions about us built over a lifetime - we carry them like trophies and crowns, convinced they make us wise. But examine if there is a quiet danger in this pride: a mind so full of what it already knows has no space left to receive anything new. Alvin Toffler in his book "Future Shock" wrote that the illiterate of the future would not be those who cannot read or write, but those who cannot learn, unlearn, and relearn. We assume learning is only about adding - a new skill, a new fact, a new opinion and to stack onto the old. Rarely do we consider that growth sometimes demands the opposite: emptying, before we can be filled again. A young scholar once travelled to an ashram, proud of the scriptures he had already mastered, eager to be taught by a revered guru. As he sat before him, reciting all he knew, the guru quietly picked up the young man's kamandal, still half filled with water, and began pouring more into it. The water spilled over, running onto the ground. "Guruji, it is already full!" the young man said, startled. The guru smiled. "So is your mind. You came here to learn, but you arrived already full of your own knowledge. Empty yourself first - only then can I offer you anything true." Most of us walk through life like that overflowing kamandal - certain, full, closed. We listen to reply, not to understand. Our mind always has to be empty to receive the new. Real learning begins only when we're willing to unlearn first. Humbly accept that our cup is full and pour it out. Today, sit with one belief or opinion you hold strongly, and ask - am I still willing to learn something that contradicts it?

-DAIV

When organisations lose the human touch



SANJAY CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

I became a member of Club Mahindra in 2010. Whenever I needed something beyond my normal entitlement-an additional room, for instance-I would write to them. Someone would call to understand my requirement. If I missed the call, they would call again. I would be placed on a waitlist and, sometimes, the additional room became available. At other times, it did not. Even then, there was an apology and an explanation. Whether I eventually got the room was not what stayed with me. Someone had listened. Someone had tried. I felt valued.

Over the past few years, I sensed a change. A missed call is sometimes followed by an email saying that I could not be contacted, bringing the conversation to an end. Recently, dissatisfied with the response to a request, I gave a poor rating on their app. An executive called but

explained that he was helpless. He could not even place me on a waitlist. When I asked for the escalation matrix, he promised to send it by email, which he never sent.

It would be easy to blame technology or the increasing scale of organisations. Yet my experiences elsewhere make me hesitate. Whenever I stay at Taj or ITC properties, I encounter employees who appear instinctively inclined to help. They cannot always fulfil a request, nor should one expect them to. But there is usually an attempt to understand whether something can be done. The difference is subtle but important. Good service is not about always saying yes. It is about making the customer feel that the request has been heard and someone has genuinely tried.

My father still narrates an incident from more than four decades ago. While browsing at Harrods in London, he inadvertently left his camera behind. He realised it only after boarding his flight back to India. This was before mobile phones and emails, when international calls were prohibitively expensive. On returning home, he wrote to the store. Sometime later, he was surprised to receive the camera. Accompanying it was a letter from Harrods apologising for the inconvenience. The customer had forgotten his camera. The store apologised.

Perhaps technology, therefore, is not the real issue. Harrods could demonstrate concern without apps, customer relationship management software or automated tracking systems.

Taj and ITC demonstrate that modern organisations

can retain the human touch. And my experience with Club Mahindra suggests that an organisation can possess that quality and gradually lose it. Why does this happen?

As organisations grow, processes become necessary. Standardisation improves efficiency and technology allows businesses to serve customers at a scale otherwise impossible. But processes also define what employees may or may not do. Somewhere along the way, an employee can stop asking, "How can I help?" and begin asking, "What does the system allow me to do?"

Perhaps this is where leadership and organisational culture matter. Employees work within the systems, authority and expectations created for them. It is leadership that determines whether procedures become rigid boundaries or allow room for empathy when circumstances demand it. Technology and growth need not make organisations impersonal; much depends on the culture created at the top. When employees know that helping customers matters as much as following a process, that understanding shapes every interaction.

Systems may become smarter and processes more efficient. But an organisation retains its beating heart only as long as its leadership remains willing to care-and creates a culture in which caring is possible.

The writer is a founder of Kala - Krazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Congress must put Punjab unity first

The reshuffle in the Congress organisation, with Sachin Pilot replacing Bhupesh Baghel as the party's Punjab in-charge, comes at a crucial juncture. With the Punjab Assembly elections approaching, the party can ill afford internal differences and factionalism. Reports of strained relations among senior Punjab leaders and the boycott of organisational meetings have undoubtedly weakened the party's preparations. Mr Pilot's appointment should therefore be seen as an opportunity to rebuild trust and bring competing factions onto a common platform. His organisational experience and relatively young age could inject fresh energy into the state unit. However, no organisational reshuffle can succeed unless Punjab Congress leaders rise above personal ambitions and work collectively. The party must concentrate on strengthening its grassroots network, addressing people's concerns and presenting voters with a credible political alternative. Mr Pilot's immediate priority should be to restore unity, discipline and effective coordination between leaders and workers. The Congress must also ensure that organisational decisions are implemented at the grassroots rather than remaining confined to party offices. If the party can turn its internal diversity into collective strength, it may yet regain political relevance in Punjab.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

Food safety crackdown must be sustained

The FDA's crackdown on food adulteration and mislabelling is an appreciable step, but such exercises must continue until they achieve their intended purpose. Other states should adopt similar measures, even if rigorous enforcement initially sends ripples through hotels, restaurants and food businesses. For years, food-safety enforcement in Maharashtra appeared to suffer from a familiar problem: plenty of rules, but insufficient fear among those who flouted them. That complacency now seems to be facing a challenge. The recent Navi Mumbai operation, conducted by the FDA with the Navi Mumbai Police Crime Branch, illustrates why sustained vigilance is necessary. Officials reportedly uncovered an alleged racket involving the removal and alteration of manufacturing and expiry dates on packaged food.

At a Turbhe establishment, 8,442 cartons linked to 10 exporter companies were seized, along with equipment allegedly used for relabelling and repackaging. Tampering with expiry dates is not merely regulatory misconduct; it undermines informed consumer choice and can endanger public health. The real test is whether such action creates a culture of routine compliance, backed by systematic, transparent and evidence-based inspections.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

India-Poland: Strategic partnership deepens

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar's recent discussions with Poland's Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Radoslaw Sikorski underline the growing importance of India-Poland relations. The visit was also reciprocal, following Mr Sikorski's visit to India in January. The two sides focused on promising areas including investment, manufacturing, space technology, defence, semiconductors, artificial intelligence and green energy.

Bilateral trade, already worth around \$6.3 billion, provides a strong foundation for further economic engagement. India and Poland established diplomatic relations in 1954, and their ties were elevated to a strategic partnership in 2024 during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Warsaw—the first by an Indian Prime Minister in 45 years. It is encouraging that the Action Plan for 2024–2028 is now being actively pursued. People-to-people ties provide another important dimension.

A sizeable Indian community lives in Poland, while many Indian students pursue higher education there. Poland also extended valuable assistance to India during the Covid-19 pandemic, including medical equipment. Greater cooperation in emerging technologies, defence, education and clean energy could give this strategic partnership substantial depth in the years ahead.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Bihar must get a voice in the Ganga water-sharing deal

As India-Bangladesh Ganga Water Sharing Treaty approaches its expiry, Bihar faces a crucial moment in its long-running struggle over water. The state bears the consequences of upstream extraction and downstream obligations at Farakka, yet has had little say in decisions that directly affect its agriculture, and livelihoods



SUDHAKAR SINGH SUBODH KUMAR MEHTA

The Ganga is not merely a 2,525-kilometer-long ecological lifeline; it is also the epicentre of a deepening hydro-political conflict within Indian federalism. In Bihar, the Ganga spans a length of approximately 16,205 square kilometers, with nearly 80 percent of the state's geographical region falling under the Ganga river plains or its sub-basins. While Bihar's internal tributaries contribute over 50 percent of the river's total water flow during the dry season, the state remains a victim of severe downstream hydrological neglect. Upper-riparian states such as Uttar Pradesh and Haryana extract massive volumes of water for urban centers and intensive agriculture. Consequently, the natural flow of the river reaching Bihar is drastically depleted. Despite this, the full burden of meeting downstream and international supply mandates at Farakka falls squarely on Bihar.

To understand Bihar's developmental crisis, it is essential to analyse how upper-riparian extraction, central neglect, and treaty allocations have systematically marginalized the state. Furthermore, downstream obligations mandate that adequate water flow reaches the Farakka Barrage to fulfill national navigation demands at the Kolkata and Haldia ports. The Kolkata and Haldia ports serve not only West Bengal but also connect landlocked states like Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, and Nepal to maritime routes, while simultaneously honouring international treaty terms with Bangladesh.

As a result, the onus of maintaining this downstream flow falls almost entirely on the tributaries merging into the Ganga within Bihar. To protect its citizens from recurring droughts, severe floods, and ecological imbalances, the Government of Bihar has repeatedly raised the fundamental issue of equitable and fair water usage by upper-riparian states. In 1991, the state constituted the Second Bihar State Irrigation Commission to evaluate water resource issues. The commission concluded that during dry months (March and April), the sub-basin's contribution to the Ganga was significantly lower than the central requirements assessed by the Central Water Commission (CWC) in 1982, which mandated a flow of 1,500 cusecs at Farakka. This forces Bihar to release nearly three times its designated share of water. To bridge this gap between water availability and downstream mandates, the Central Government must restrict water extraction by upper-riparian states during the dry season (January to April). An effective water flow mechanism at Farakka is urgently needed to safeguard downstream interests.

Bihar has been consistently side-lined in inter-state and international meetings and discussions. During the construction of the Kanpur Barrage (1995) on the Ganga, the Uttar Pradesh government was invited for special consultations, while downstream interests were ignored. During a debate in the State Assembly on June 30, 1995, the Bihar government argued that before the river's ecological health is permanently threatened, the Central Government must address these systemic imbalances. Bihar expressed strong disagreement with the 1996 Ganga Water Sharing Treaty with Bangladesh because, despite being a major riparian state, it was excluded from the core negotiations.

Although international treaties fall entirely under the constitutional domain of the Central Government, water management remains a State subject. Excluding middle/upper-riparian states like Bihar from treaty negotiations creates a severe imbalance in cooperative federalism, especially when extensive consultations are conducted with downstream states like West Bengal. Signed on December 12, 1996, the 30-year treaty aims to share Ganga waters for mutual benefits in flood management, irrigation, basin development, and hydropower.

The treaty mandates a 50-50 allocation during peak dry season, provided that each country receives a minimum of 35,000 cusecs of water in alternating 10-day cycles between March 1 and May 10. Despite Bihar's limited



ALTHOUGH INTERNATIONAL TREATIES FALL ENTIRELY UNDER THE CONSTITUTIONAL DOMAIN OF THE CENTRAL GOVERNMENT, WATER MANAGEMENT REMAINS A STATE SUBJECT. EXCLUDING MIDDLE/UPPER-RIPARIAN STATES LIKE BIHAR FROM TREATY NEGOTIATIONS CREATES A SEVERE IMBALANCE IN COOPERATIVE FEDERALISM, ESPECIALLY WHEN EXTENSIVE CONSULTATIONS ARE CONDUCTED WITH DOWNSTREAM STATES LIKE WEST BENGAL.

Sudhakar Singh is Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha, RJD) & Prof. Subodh Kumar Mehta is National Spokesperson of RJD

voice in international water allocation, its role at the Farakka Barrage remains the most critical. During the dry season, when the Ganga enters Buxar in Bihar from Uttar Pradesh, its flow drops to approximately 4,000 cusecs. To meet the minimum threshold set by the treaty at Farakka, 75 percent of the required additional water is supplied by Bihar's internal tributaries (Gandak, Kosi, Ghaghara, Mahananda, and Son). In the absence of adequate water storage facilities, uncontrolled monsoon flows cause widespread devastation in North Bihar through severe flooding. Constructing a flood-control dam in the upper catchment area of the Kosi River in Nepal could prove to be a crucial pivot for Bihar's safety and regional development.

Following the devastating floods of 2007, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar formed a high-level technical committee comprising experts from the Central Water Commission, Ganga Flood Control Commission, and Central Water and Power Research Station, headed by Nilendu Sanyal. The committee recommended regular monitoring, anti-silting measures, and dredging to prevent embankment breaches, alongside establishing diplomatic and technical coordination with Nepal. However, these recommendations were never implemented. The Sanyal Committee never identified the Farakka Barrage as the primary cause of flooding, nor did it demand its decommissioning. Despite this, going against the report of the technical committee set up by his own government, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar submitted a proposal to a central expert committee in 2017, arguing that the Farakka Barrage acts as an obstruction by trapping heavy amounts of silt upstream, raising the riverbed level of the Ganga and causing floods in Bihar.

Thus, Bihar officially requested the Central Government to consider decommissioning it. Conversely, technical committees formed by the Bihar government from time to time have not attributed the siltation problem to the Farakka Barrage. Construction of the Farakka Barrage began in 1961, specifically designed to divert Ganga water into the Bhagirathi-Hooghly river system to flush silt from the Kolkata and Haldia ports. The Farakka Barrage is an economic lifeline for the Kolkata and Haldia ports and a vital maritime corridor for a landlocked state like Bihar.

As we know that, following the partition of India, the lower portion of the Ganga went to East Pakistan (now Bangladesh), cutting off maritime trade access for Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, and Nepal. Moreover, removing the barrage would escalate inter-state conflicts, as West Bengal relies on it for water supply, power plants, and irrigation. The Central Water Commission also periodically prioritizes desilting and dredging.

As the 1996 Ganga Water Sharing Treaty reaches the end of its 30-year term on December 12, 2026, the Bihar government must demand formal representation in the treaty renegotiations. Even though water sharing is a central subject, Bihar endures its physical consequences. An institutionalized role in the Joint River Commission's negotiation delegation alongside West Bengal is the need of the hour.

The Samrat Choudhary administration must present comprehensive data on agricultural, industrial, and drinking water requirements for the next 30 years. Furthermore, the scientific data compiled by the Second Bihar Irrigation Commission should serve as an important baseline. The Bihar government must urge the Centre to implement a National Silt Management Policy focused on systematic dredging. The Central Government should also direct upper-riparian states to engage in formal dialogue with Bihar. The upcoming deadline offers an opportunity to update the 30-year-old framework using modern climate data. Today's necessity is to maintain a balance in foreign relations with Bangladesh while addressing Bihar's legitimate concerns regarding drought and flood management. Only a collaborative and equitable framework can restore the ecological health of the Ganga while safeguarding the social and economic stability of all riparian stakeholders.

Gearing up to eliminate tuberculosis



GOBARDHAN DAS SIMARJOT KAUR

India is marching towards becoming a developed nation by 2047, eliminating TB is no longer simply about saving lives, it is about reducing healthcare costs and demonstrating India's ability to solve a global problem through indigenous innovation. Over the past decade, India has significantly strengthened its fight against Tuberculosis (TB) through the National TB Elimination Programme (NTEP). Although the ambitious 2025 elimination target remains a work in progress, it has accelerated investments in diagnostics, treatment and patient support. The results are encouraging. According to the WHO Global TB Report 2025, India's TB incidence has declined by 21%, from 237 to 187 cases per lakh population between 2015 and 2024, almost twice the global rate of decline. During the same period, TB mortality fell by 25%, while treatment coverage improved dramatically from 53% to 92%, reflecting stronger case detection and better access to care. Digital platforms such as Ni-kshay, nutritional support through the Ni-kshay Poshan Yojana, expanded molecular diagnostics and nationwide community campaigns under TB Mukta Bharat have together transformed India's TB response, laying a strong foundation for eventual elimination.

Despite this progress, the battle is far from over. Drug-resistant TB remains a serious threat, requiring longer treatment, higher costs and more complex clinical management. Delayed diagnosis, undernutrition, diabetes, overcrowded living conditions and social stigma continue to fuel transmission. Addressing these issues will require stronger public health systems alongside continued scientific innovation. Scientific innovation is changing the landscape of TB treatment. New medicines such as Bedaquiline, Delamanid and Pretomanid have significantly improved outcomes for patients with drug-resistant TB by enabling shorter and more effective treatment regimens. Researchers are also working on improved vaccines, rapid diagnostics and host-directed therapies that strengthen the body's immune response against infection.

India is not merely adopting these innovations; it is actively developing them. The Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) and its National Institute for Research in Tuberculosis (NIRT) are leading research on new diagnostics, treatment strategies and disease surveillance. The Department of Biotechnology (DBT) and the Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC) are supporting startups and research institutions working on vaccines, diagnostics and novel therapeutics, helping build a stronger indigenous innovation ecosystem. Indian industry is also playing a crucial role. Companies such as Macleods Pharmaceuticals, Lupin, Cipla and Cadila Pharmaceuticals manufacture affordable anti-TB medicines that are used across India and also exported to many low and middle-income countries. Meanwhile, Molbio Diagnostics has developed the portable Truenat platform, enabling rapid molecular diagnosis even in remote healthcare settings. These achievements reinforce India's position as not only the "Pharmacy of the world" but also an emerging hub for affordable healthcare innovation.

Beyond conventional medicines, Indian scientists are exploring natural and host-directed therapies that could improve TB treatment. Researchers at the CSIR-Indian Institute of Integrative Medicine (IIIM) and the CSIR-Central Drug Research Institute (CDRI) are studying bioactive compounds from medicinal plants such as Ashwagandha, Turmeric, Giloy and Black Pepper for their immune-modulating properties. While these therapies are still under investigation and cannot replace standard treatment, they may eventually complement existing medicines by improving patient recovery. Unlike many Western countries, where TB has become relatively uncommon, India continues to face unique demographic and socio-economic conditions that sustain transmission. High population density, nutritional deficiencies and unequal access to healthcare mean that solutions developed elsewhere may not fully address India's needs. This makes indigenous innovation essential. Affordable diagnostics, vaccines and medicines designed and manufactured in India will not only strengthen national health security but can also serve other high-burden countries facing similar challenges. The next phase of India's TB strategy must move beyond disease management to innovation leadership. Greater investment in biotechnology, vaccine development, genomic surveillance and public-private partnerships will be essential to develop affordable, scalable solutions. Equally important will be improving nutrition, sanitation, early diagnosis and awareness, since eliminating TB requires both scientific breakthroughs and stronger community health systems. India now has an opportunity to redefine its role in the global fight against TB. The country possesses world-class scientific institutions, a robust pharmaceutical industry, and a rapidly growing biotechnology ecosystem. By combining strong public policy with indigenous research and private-sector innovation, India can move beyond managing the world's largest TB burden to developing solutions for the world. The fight against TB is no longer only about eliminating a disease, it is about demonstrating India's ability to lead through science, innovation and affordable healthcare. India's sustained commitment and investment is likely to become a model for TB elimination across the world.



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India's next fiscal challenge is climate risk



ANURADHA PS

Climate change in India has been looked upon more as an environmental issue for decades. This then turned into a development challenge and now to a fiscal risk. Transport networks and supply chains can be paralysed during a flood. Heatwaves may decrease productivity from work and increase electricity consumption. During drought, the real purchasing power gets affected and farm incomes. Cyclones can cause damage to public infrastructure, disrupt activities of businesses and affect the provision of essential services.

The expenses continue after these uncertainties. Governments need to fund relief, reconstruction, social protection and the restoration of public assets, which may occur at a time when economies are already strained, and public revenues are already limited. Beyond the standard budget debates, a critical question remains unaddressed: what is the true fiscal cost of climate change for India?

The costs of activities aimed at addressing climate change and its impacts are already significant in India. But the difficulty is that this is distributed across ministries, sectors and programmes and the fiscal exposure is not clear.

The National Institute of Public Finance and Policy did a study in 2020 that estimated the expenditure related to climate programmes accounts for about 5-6 per cent of all national budgetary expenditure, of which a significant portion is specifically targeted.

A threat to the financial stability

A study of climate change and fiscal deficits in India in 2026 finds that compared to the overall government expenditure the coefficient of variation of the climate related expenditure is very high, at 26.4 per cent. It also detects higher budget differences in sectors vulnerable to climate change. The figures must be taken with a pinch of salt as they are based on how climate-related spending is categorized.

The relevance is not just on the side of increased spending by governments due to climate change. It could increase the uncertainty of public expenditure. In India, IAC projects total adaptation needs of ₹56.68 trillion up to 2030 in a business-as-usual (BAU) scenario. Further, NITI Aayog has also pointed out that the potential climate-damage cost to India by 2030 will be ₹15.5 trillion. These are scenario-based estimates, rather than obligations which have to show up in government accounts.

The establishment of another independent Indian climate fund is not necessarily required in India. It requires a Union Budget's Climate Fiscal Risk Statement. The statement needs to stipulate five areas: What are the most flood, drought, heat-wave, cyclone and water stress exposed sectors, states and public assets? What contingencies might



be the risks that governments would be exposed to following a severe climate event?

There are models from other countries to be learned: The UK's Office for Budget Responsibility (OBR) looks at the impact of physical climate impact, adaptation and transition to a low carbon economy on borrowing and public debt. The Treasury has also added climate change and adverse weather response considerations to its long-term economic and fiscal analysis of New Zealand. In the Philippines, the Climate Change Expenditure Tagging (CCET) method is employed to identify, monitor and report on climate-related expenditure in the budget process. India requires both aspects: knowing the amount of spending it is doing on climate action, and what climate change could do to the public finances.

Fiscal reviews typically focus on lower growth, higher interest rates, and lower revenues. Climate shocks should be incorporated into the same exercise. If a big flood does the damage, what will

happen to a state's finances? What occurs following successive droughts to agricultural and rural-support expenditure?

The IMF's Quantitative Climate Change Risk Assessment Fiscal Tool (Q-CRAFT) is a tool that can be used by governments to analyse the implications of climate scenarios for a country's macro-economic and fiscal indicators, including government debt. These should be adopted systematically throughout India starting at the Union level and gradually moving on to make climate-fiscal assessments at the state level. States have to be included.

They carry the brunt of the initial expense of wrecked roads, drainage, water systems, agriculture, health services and disaster response. But they have different financial means. The fiscal federalism aspect of climate risk is therefore also a question. Efforts of the 16th Finance Commission provide a useful context for understanding how intergovernmental transfers can help address variations in climate exposure, climate resilience requirements and fiscal capacity.

Fiscal insurance as resilience

Often, a resilient drainage system or heat-resistant public infrastructure and drought-resilient agriculture are regarded as extra costs. It should instead be seen as some future expenditure that is not incurred. The value of an investment can't just be based on its initial cost if it lowers reconstruction expenses the next day. Public investment appraisal should also take into account losses and liabilities that resilience can avoid. The same principle goes

for insurance. If a loss is not covered by insurance then governments fill the gap as insurers of last resort. By using appropriate catastrophe insurance, parametric insurance and other risk-transfer mechanisms, a more manageable share of losses for governments can be reduced following disasters. The transition to the lower carbon economy is also a part of climate-risk accounting. The fuel-tax revenues and subsidies could be impacted by changes in the consumption of fossil fuels, and the transition to renewable energy, electricity grids, storage, green mobility and worker adjustment will involve investments.

Progress has been made in India with regard to monitoring climate investment and bolstering disaster management. It is now time to reflect climate risk in fiscal policy. The impacts of climate change can build up over time – from repeated floods, crop failures, "heat-stressed" cities, damaged infrastructure, increased reconstruction costs, and the increased need for public support. These pressures, when clearly apparent in government accounts, come on the back of fiscal space having been restricted. India is facing a new hurdle of budget administration: not only is there a question of how much it spends, but also of how well India's public finances will withstand a changing climate. Rather than being reshaped by climate change, its budgets have to anticipate the risks of climate change.

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Delhi HC quashes FIR arising out of fight between friends



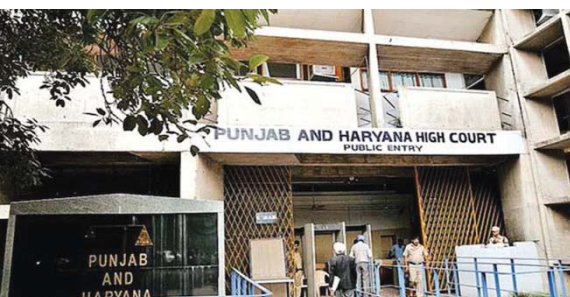
The Delhi High Court has quashed an FIR that was lodged following a fight between friends as the dispute has been amicably settled, and directed them to do community service at a hospital in Manipur.

Noting that the complainant and the two accused remain friends and harbour no subsisting grievance against each other, the high court said the likelihood of the proceedings culminating in a conviction is remote and continuation of the criminal proceedings would serve no useful purpose.

"... I am of the view that it would be appropriate to make the relief sought (quashing of FIR) subject to undertaking community service and paying appropriate costs. The petitioner and respondent no. 4 (both accused) shall undertake community service for a total of six sessions of two hours each at Regional Institute of Medical Science, Manipur," Justice Prateek Jalan said in an order passed on August 21.

The court said both the friends should report to the hospital's medical superintendent who would assign suitable duties to them. The community service should be completed within two months from the date of commencement after which the medical superintendent would issue a compliance certificate and it should be placed on court's record. The court also directed the two men to collectively pay ₹10,000 to the Delhi High Court Bar Association within two weeks. The court passed the order while allowing a plea seeking quashing of an FIR lodged at the Dabri Police Station here. (PTI)

Punjab Government objects to appointment of Ashwani Kumar Mishra as HC chief justice



The Punjab Cabinet on Sunday evening passed a resolution against the Centre notifying the appointment of Ashwani Kumar Mishra as the Chief Justice of Punjab and Haryana High Court, claiming it was done without awaiting the state government's views bypassing Constitutional norms and set procedures.

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann also wrote separate letters to President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, urging the Centre not to move forward with the administration of oath to Justice Mishra, which is scheduled for Monday, "till the state government's concerns are adequately addressed".

However, Additional Solicitor General of India, Satya Pal Jain, said the controversy raised by the Punjab Government over the appointment is "most unfortunate and totally uncalled for", and asserted that the state had sufficient time to send its views. He said the Supreme Court collegium on August 6 recommended the names for the appointment of Chief Justice of eight high courts.

"All the state governments except Punjab sent their views within a week... No one has the right to sit over the proposal for an indefinite period with a view to scuttle the judicial process and politicise a non-political issue," Jain said in a statement and added that states do not hold a "veto" power on these appointments. (PTI)

SC to hear on September 7 plea seeking guidelines to control unpredictable fluctuations in airfare

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a plea seeking regulatory guidelines to control the "unpredictable fluctuations" in airfare and ancillary charges imposed by private airlines in India.

As per the apex court's cause list of September 7, the matter would be heard by a bench comprising Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta. On August 17, the Centre had told the top court that it has fast-tracked the framing of rules under the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024, which is aimed at modernising India's aviation sector, and the same would be finalised within three weeks.

The government had placed the draft rules before the bench in a sealed cover and said some final discus-



sions were going on.

The apex court had noted that Additional Solicitor General Anil Kaushik, appearing for the Centre, sought three-week time to get the draft rules finalised and place it before the court.

The top court is hearing a plea filed by social activist S Lexminarayanan, who has sought a robust and independent regulator that ensures transparency and passenger protection across the civil

Supreme Court order on Jantar Mantar protest helps buy time



RANJIT KUMAR SINHA

On September 1, 2026, the Supreme Court used its extraordinary powers under Article 142 of the Constitution to quash FIRs registered across India linked to protests led by the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP). These demonstrations centered around Jantar Mantar and spread across surrounding areas in the heart of the national Capital.

The orders applied to cases filed in Delhi, Bihar, Maharashtra, West Bengal, and Assam regarding demonstrations held between July 20 and 25. The Top Court closed similar FIRs in other states and barred new ones over those incidents.

Calling the ruling a "healing balm," the Apex Court said criminal cases should not ruin the futures of young students making democratic demands. However, police can still act against individuals with serious criminal records identified via facial recognition technology.

The order codified a negotiated deal between the Centre, state governments,

and the CJP. In return for legal relief, the CJP dropped its planned September 5 march from Jantar Mantar toward key government offices in New Delhi. The Centre also agreed to clear cases and frame a national compensation policy for affected families.

The outcome offered strategic wins to both sides. For CJP and Students, they cleared their legal records, won government compensation commitments, validated their movement at Jantar Mantar, and secured a graceful exit.

For the Government, authorities defused a major street protest at Jantar Mantar right before international events like the 18th BRICS Summit on September 12-13, 2026. They also managed public anger while keeping the right to prosecute serious criminals.

The urgency behind this compromise stems from the lessons of February 2020. During former US President Donald Trump's visit, anti-CAA protests escalated beyond designated sites into violent clashes in Northeast Delhi. That crisis showed how easily street agitations near government zones can collide with international summits, hurting the country's global image.

By using Article 142, the Supreme Court stopped a similar crisis from spilling



out of Jantar Mantar and surrounding central areas before the BRICS Summit. Using force against youth risks deepening public anger. Early court intervention stabilized the capital while protecting diplomatic optics.

The decision raises a key question: Is this a new government strategy, or just a temporary fix?

In past protests, like the farm law or CAA agitations, the government did not yield quickly. It preferred to wait out crowds and let legal cases proceed.

This time, calendar pressures changed things. The BRICS Summit was only days away, and keeping central Delhi and Jantar Mantar peaceful was crucial for world leaders arriving in the capital.

When international optics are not at stake, the govern-

ment will likely return to its tough stance. It will not step back every time a group takes to the streets.

Resolving one agitation often invites new ones. As the CJP student march was called off, fresh groups began assembling at Jantar Mantar and surrounding arterial roads.

Anti-reservation groups, including the Reservation Hatao Andolan and Kshatriya Karni Sena, are now occupying protest spots to demand changes to quota policies.

Handling these groups is much harder. Exam leaks are simple administrative fixes. Reservation policy, however, involves complex caste dynamics and voting blocks.

If the government yields to anti-reservation groups at Jantar Mantar, Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST), and Other Backward Classes (OBC) communities

Rajasthan: HC orders comprehensive framework for protecting leopard habitat in Pali district

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jodhpur



The Rajasthan High Court has put in place a comprehensive regulatory framework for protecting the leopard habitat of Jawai in Pali district, including a one-km construction-control zone around identified caves, dens, breeding sites, corridors and other critical habitat features.

A division bench of Justices Pushpendra Singh Bhati and Rekha Borana, pronouncing its order on Saturday on a PIL, directed the authorities to strictly enforce the state government's March 31, 2015 order which bars new commercial activities such as hotels, resorts, besides industrial activity including mining and land conversion, within one km of the notified Jawai Leopard Conservation Reserves.

Importantly, the bench said the one-km distance would operate as an interim, evidence-based regulatory threshold, and not as a permanent ecological boundary. The state has been asked to undertake geo-referenced mapping and ecological and carrying-capacity assessments before framing a comprehensive policy identifying areas requiring absolute protection and those where regulated activity may be

permitted.

Under the directions, no new construction, hill cutting, blasting, excavation, roads or tracks, boundary walls or commercial structures will be allowed on identified leopard habitat features, irrespective of whether the land is privately owned, revenue land, community land or forest land. Restrictions will also apply to activities that block or materially disturb leopard movement or habitat.

The order, however, makes exceptions for bona fide residential construction within existing village abadi areas, repair or reconstruction of lawful houses without material expansion, and essential public facilities such as schools, Anganwadis, dispensaries and drinking-water infrastructure.

Traditional agriculture, grazing and customary livelihood activities have also been protected, subject to

premise.

Mining restrictions imposed earlier will continue, while new barbed-wire fencing, solid walls or other compartmentalisation obstructing wildlife movement have also been prohibited. Existing fencing found to obstruct recognised wildlife corridors may be removed or modified after notice to the landholder.

The judgment came on the PIL filed by Apoorva Agrawat, seeking protection of leopard caves, dens, breeding sites and movement corridors and regulation of construction, tourism and safari activities in Jawai.

Earlier interim orders had restricted wildlife-spotting activities to specified hours and prohibited artificial devices such as spotlights and drones. On April 28, the court had also restrained construction without its permission, stayed mining and prohibited further barbed-wire fencing.

The bench has now merged the previous interim orders on three occasions dated March 23, April 20 and April 28 with the final judgment, making the new framework operative for the Jawai landscape. The District Collector and Deputy Conservator of Forests, Pali, have been assigned responsibility for inter-departmental implementation.

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HC dismisses plea seeking FIR against spiritual leader



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Allahabad High Court has dismissed a writ petition seeking the registration of an FIR against spiritual leader Rambhadracharya over his alleged objectionable remarks about the Upadhyay community and revered religious personalities, including the Shankaracharyas.

A two-judge bench comprising Justices Chandra Dhari Singh and Tarun Saxena observed that a person aggrieved by the non-registration of an FIR must ordinarily first exhaust the statutory remedies available under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) prior to invoking the high court's extraordinary jurisdiction under Article 226. In its order dated September 1, the court dismissed the writ petition filed by Ramesh Upadhyay of Varanasi. However, he was granted liberty to avail appropriate remedy under law.

According to the petitioner, certain statements made by

Rambhadracharya, the founder and head of Tulsi Peeth in Chitrakoot, caused "grave mental agony, humiliation and insult" to him and other members of the Upadhyay community.

The petitioner alleged that Rambhadracharya also made objectionable statements against the four Shankaracharyas, hurting the religious sentiments of several followers. Videos of his statements were circulated on social media platforms, including YouTube, he claimed.

The petitioner apprised the court that he had submitted a complaint to Commissioner of Police, Varanasi, on October 8, 2025, seeking the registration of an FIR against the spiritual leader under appropriate penal provisions. However, no FIR had been registered till date. The State opposed the petition contending that the petitioner had not approached the concerned police station and had directly approached HC without first availing the remedy under Section 175(3) BNSS before the magistrate.

25 Collegium recommendations for appointing HC judges pending with Government

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Twenty-five names recommended by the Supreme Court Collegium for appointment as high court judges largely across five high courts are pending with the government, with the oldest one being of advocate Saurabh Kirpal awaiting a final decision since October 2017.

The number of recommendations for appointment as high court judges pending with the central government have gone down considerably as compared to the recent past, sources aware of the process to appoint Supreme Court and high court judges told PTI. The 25 names are largely "scattered" across Delhi, Calcutta, Madras, Punjab and Haryana and Gujarat high courts, besides others. Son of former CJI B N Kirpal, Saurabh Kirpal's name was sent by the Delhi High Court Collegium to the SC collegium in October 2017 for elevation as a high court judge. But the top court collegium is learnt to have deferred deliberations on his name three times. Finally, the collegium headed by then CJI N V Ramana took a decision in favour of



Kirpal in November 2021. In November next year, the government had returned his file to the SC collegium for reconsideration. After the collegium reiterated its stand, the file has remained pending.

The sources cited above said the other names pending with the government are relatively new except two others besides that of Kirpal.

High court collegiums send their recommendations to appoint judicial officers and advocates as judges to the department of justice in the Union law

ministry. The department adds details, including IB reports, about the recommendee or candidate before forwarding it to the Supreme Court collegium.

The collegium, in its wisdom, either recommends name for appointment as high court judge or returns the file to the high court collegium. The latest combined sanctioned strength of the 25 high courts is 1,122 judges. With 304 vacancies, the working strength stands at 818 judges. In percentage terms, 27 per cent of high court posts are currently vacant.

(Hitopadesha)

MORAL OF THE STORY: Where greed breeds quarrel, the cunning reap the reward.

FROMTHE

WORLD

CAPE VERDE

25 people dead in bus crash

At least 25 people were killed in a traffic accident in the African island nation of Cape Verde, local media and officials said Sunday. The accident, which occurred on the Campanas de Cima route, a mountainous area in Fogo Island, occurred on Saturday and involved a passenger bus. Several people were also injured. Education officials said the outing was not organised by local schools but was an annual trip privately arranged by the driver, who was among those killed. (AP)

CONGO

Fire in Kinshasa leaves 22 dead

A fire at a wedding party in Congo's capital Kinshasa left at least 22 people dead, the regional mayor said Saturday. Several others were injured. The fire started Friday night and continued into early Saturday in a building in Lingwala in northern Kinshasa. The building's narrow hallways were constricted by people trying to escape the fire. Several people - some alive and some dead - were laid by the roadside as attendees tried to help those who were still alive. The mayor of Lingwala, Norbert Mushinga, told the Congolese Press Agency that the provisional death toll was 22. He said the toll could rise further. The exact cause of the fire was unconfirmed. "It is a tragedy," Jacquemin Shabani, Congo's deputy prime minister and interior minister, said. The minister visited the site Saturday morning. Deadly fires are common in densely populated areas of Kinshasa where urban development is often implemented without provisions such as fire services. Fires are common during the dry season and several have taken place this year, according to local media. (AP)

US envoys, Kushner arrive in Kyiv

SAMYA KULLAB ■ Kyiv

US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner arrived in Kyiv on Sunday in their first official visit to Ukraine as part of a renewed push for peace after Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine. Their trip follows a meeting with Russian President Vladimir Putin in Moscow on Saturday, seeking to revive peace talks during escalating aerial attacks by both sides. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Sunday that Kyiv is ready for a "constructive" discussion with US representatives. "We are interested in bringing the end of the war closer. Peace is needed. Security guarantees are needed. A just and sustainable postwar peace is needed. Our proposals are prepared," he said in a post on Telegram. Washington's push to end the fighting has lost momentum, with the United States focused for the past six months on the Iran war. The last known visit to Moscow by Witkoff and Kushner, US President Donald Trump's son-in-law, was in January when they also held talks with Putin at the Kremlin.



Saturday's meeting in Moscow lasted more than three hours behind closed doors and ended without announcements of any breakthroughs. Putin's foreign policy adviser, Yuri Ushakov, described them afterward as constructive, frank, and useful but didn't discuss specific outcomes.

While Moscow offered its "comprehensive assessment" of the battlefield situation in Ukraine, Ushakov said, the talks were not purely focused on the war in Ukraine. "Economic issues and potentially large, mutually beneficial joint projects for Russia and America were discussed in considerable

detail," he said. The air war between Russia and Ukraine has intensified as troops have struggled to make progress along the 1,250-kilometre (775-mile) front line. Russia has recently been using fast-flying, jet-powered drones, and the recurring wail of air-raid sirens has become part of daily life in Kyiv.

Putin and Zelenskyy had agreed to pause strikes on each other's capitals while the talks take place. Still, the two traded fire overnight into Sunday, officials said. Russian attacks across multiple Ukrainian regions killed one person and injured at least 10 others overnight into Sunday, Ukraine's State Emergency Service said. In Zaporizhzhia, drone strikes killed a 74-year-old man and wounded three people, while a drone damaged an apartment building, injuring seven people, in the Khmelnytskyi region. Ukraine's air force said Sunday that it intercepted 82 drones out of the 108 launched by Russia overnight, along with six missiles. In Russia, a man was killed and a woman seriously wounded when a Ukrainian drone struck a vehicle, local authorities in the Belgorod border region said. The Russian Defence Ministry said Sunday that its air defences overnight shot down 258 Ukrainian drones over 14 Russian regions, occupied Crimea and the waters of the Black and Azov seas. In Kyiv on Sunday, dozens gathered

for a nationwide 9 am moment of silence honouring Ukraine's fallen soldiers, a daily ritual held in cities across the country. Among them was Nataliia Lipei, 67, whose son Viktor was killed in December 2022. Despite a health condition, she has travelled from city to city to take part, and she said she hopes the talks in Moscow and Kyiv will finally bring an end to the war. "I hope these steps and these meetings will definitely produce results, because there has been so much bloodshed and so many deaths here that we have to stop all of this," she told The Associated Press. Not everyone shared her hope for the talks. Oleksandr Pastukhov, 27, a video editor who joined the commemoration, was sceptical the envoys' visit would change anything. "We've already seen delegations like this come here before," he said. "We've seen this so-called ceasefire for three days, which ended after just a couple of hours, and now we're supposed to naively think that two people will come and change something." (AP)

Nepal requests countries to limit travel advisories to flood-hit areas

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kathmandu

Nepal has urged friendly countries to confine travel advisories to specific flood-affected areas, while highlighting that the rest of the country remains open and safe for travel and tourism. The country's Ministry of Foreign Affairs said on Sunday that it and Nepal's missions abroad were working closely with friendly countries on the issue. The request comes after the United States issued a travel advisory on September 4, placing Nepal under Level 2, or "Exercise increased caution," due to natural disasters.



The US advisory places the Rasuwagadhi-Timure-Syafubesi area of Rasuwa district, including the Nepal-China border crossing, under Level 4, or "Do not travel", due to flood damage, disrupted transportation and communications, ongoing search-and-rescue and recovery operations, and the risk of additional flooding and landslides. "Nepal regularly experiences earthquakes, floods, and landslides. Earthquakes can happen suddenly with little warning, including in the Kathmandu Valley," the advisory said. Also, foreign journalists seeking to cover the flood-affected areas are required to obtain press accreditation through the Department of Information and Broadcasting's online service, the Foreign Ministry said. The ministry said the requirement was in view of the risks associated with ongoing rescue operations, unstable terrain, landslide hazards and helicopter operations. Meanwhile, Nepal has facilitated the return of 431 Nepali nationals who were stranded on the Chinese side after the floods, with the ministry coordinating with Chinese authorities. They returned through the Tatopani border point, while another 105 were expected to return through the same border point, the ministry said.

Singapore never allow prejudice against any community: PM Wong

GURDIP SINGH ■ Singapore

Singapore must never allow prejudice against any community to become accepted or normalised, Prime Minister Lawrence Wong said on Sunday, days after racist and xenophobic comments appeared online about the Nepal-Tibet flash floods disaster and the Singapore Airlines-Air India partnership. "We can and should have robust debates. But we should never use seemingly legitimate arguments as a cover to fuel prejudice against any community or hostility towards foreigners," the Channel News Asia quoted Wong as saying. The prime minister's remarks come a day after Singapore Senior Minister K Shanmugam said police are investigating "shameful" and "totally unacceptable" racist and xenophobic comments posted online about the Nepal-Tibet flood disaster and Singapore Airlines' (SIA) investment in Air India. In a Facebook post, Wong said that "an uglier side" had emerged in online discussions about the two matters. Racist comments surfaced online targeting some of the nine

Singaporeans missing in the Nepal-Tibet disaster, while questions about SIA's investment in Air India were "accompanied by anti-Indian abuse", he said. While such views do not represent Singapore, they should not be dismissed as "harmless online chatter", he said. "If such behaviour goes unchecked, it can become normalised, deepen mistrust between communities, and pull us apart," Wong said, adding that he had discussed the developments with his Cabinet colleagues and that this was why Shanmugam had spoken about it. Singapore has an overall population of over six million - of which 75 per cent are Chinese, 15 per cent Malays, about nine per cent Indians and the rest from other countries. The prosperous city-state is trying to manage a declining population due to a low local birth rate and depends on foreign talent to maintain its high-performance economic activities as part of the global network, which has already been badly hit by the West Asian conflict, a diplomatic observer said. Wong said that Singapore had encountered similar tensions



Singapore Prime Minister Lawrence Wong

before, pointing to how "anti-foreigner" and "racial sentiments" were stirred up during the COVID-19 pandemic and surfaced during debates over the Singapore-India Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement. Such sentiments also surfaced during the 2025 general election, when Wong spoke out against attempts to bring race and religion into politics. "There will always be people who seek to exploit our differ-

ences," Wong said. While it is impossible to prevent every hateful comment from appearing online, Singaporeans could choose how they respond to them, he said. "We can reject such views, and refuse to give them more space or legitimacy." "Singapore has held together because we have consistently rejected attempts to divide us along racial or religious lines, and chosen instead to recognise one another as fellow

Singaporeans," said the prime minister. Former prime minister and now a Senior Minister in the Cabinet, Lee Hsien Loong, on Sunday also called on Singaporeans to "stand by one another regardless of race, language or religion". In a Facebook post, Lee described racist comments directed at the Indian community in Singapore following the recent floods in Nepal as "deeply troubling". He added that it was "equally troubling" when issues such as SIA's investment in Air India were "distorted or exploited to stir vicious racial, anti-Indian resentment". Expressing his condolences to those affected by floods, Lee said the tragedy had left many families grieving and that response should be one of "compassion and solidarity". He also noted that Shanmugam had "laid out the issues clearly" in his statement on Saturday. "When incidents like this happen, leaders must speak up with force and conviction, to call out what is happening, condemn the manipulation of base emotions, and call on all Singaporeans to stand together," the Channel quoted Lee as saying.

Dar talks bilateral issues with Saudi, Turkiye FMs

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan's Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar on Sunday held separate telephone conversations with his counterparts from Saudi Arabia, Turkiye and Egypt, discussing bilateral and regional issues. The Foreign Office (FO), in a series of posts on social media platform X, said Dar held telephonic talks with Saudi Foreign Minister Faisal bin Farhan, Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan and Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty. In his call with the Saudi foreign minister, the two leaders discussed regional and international developments, including matters of



mutual interest at multilateral fora. "They also discussed follow-up on the understandings reached at the inaugural meeting of the Strategic Political and Defence Committee of the Makkah Defence Alliance, held in Istanbul, and agreed to remain in close contact," the FO said. Dar also spoke to Fidan and thanked him for hosting the inaugural meeting

of the Strategic Political and Defence Committee under the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement in Istanbul on August 31. The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement was signed by Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkiye in Makkah on August 7. It provides that an armed attack against any one of the three countries will be regarded as an attack against

all three, and calls for enhanced defence cooperation among them. The FO said the two followed up on understandings reached at the Istanbul meeting and discussed ways to further advance cooperation under the framework. "The two foreign ministers also exchanged views on regional and international developments. They also discussed matters of mutual interest and opportunities to further strengthen cooperation at multilateral fora," FO added. Earlier in the day, Dar held a conversation with Abdelatty and exchanged views on Pakistan-Egypt bilateral relations and regional and international developments. (PTI)

Iran claims strike on US ship in Hormuz

SAMY MAGDY/JULIA FRANKEL ■ Cairo

Iran said Sunday it struck an unmanned US vessel trying to enter the Strait of Hormuz, the latest salvo in a new flare-up of fighting between the two countries. The US did not immediately confirm the purported attack, which came a day after the US military said forces struck three Iranian oil tankers in response to a missile attack on Navy warships. The war began with US and Israeli attacks on Iran on Feb 28. But since a ceasefire agreement was announced in June, on-and-off fighting has persisted with both sides trying to inflict military and economic pain as negotia-



tions have collapsed. The US and Iran resumed attacks last week, following a month of relative calm, with the Strait of Hormuz and Iranian communities along it again being targeted. At least five people were killed earlier in the week during a US bombardment of southern Iran. The Trump administration appears to have adopted a dual-prong approach to the conflict, responding militarily to attacks on the strait while going after foreign financial institutions that handle Iran's money. But Tehran's hard-line new senior leaders have signalled the willingness to dig in after weathering decades of sanctions. Iran has found ways over the years to circumvent sanctions, and now the US blockade, and get its oil to buyers to help ease growing eco-

mic pressures. That relies in part on a shadow fleet transporting its oil. Meanwhile, Iran's nuclear programme, the issue that contributed to the outbreak of the war, was meant to be addressed in negotiations that fell apart soon after the US and Iran signed a memorandum of understanding in mid-June. Diplomats say the US, Britain, France and Germany seek to refer Iran to the UN Security Council for failure to comply with its nuclear non-proliferation obligations. Instead, Tehran's new leverage focuses on the Strait of Hormuz that is crucial to global oil and natural gas shipments and was seen as an international waterway before the war began. (AP)

First images show devastation from flash floods at Tibet-Nepal border

KJM VARMA ■ Gyirong (Tibet-Nepal border)

One of the most haunting reminders of the August 26 flash floods that devastated the Tibet-Nepal border is a video showing a massive wall of mud, rocks and debris engulfing a well-built immigration post in seconds. The dramatic footage, which went viral worldwide, offered a chilling glimpse of nature's fury and the devastating impact it can have on buildings and human lives. Until now, the full extent of the destruction had largely been seen from the Nepalese side of the border. In Nepal, the death toll has crossed

1,300, while around 5,000 remain missing. The disaster was triggered by an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, sending a massive surge of water and debris downstream through the Bhotekoshi River and devastating settlements in northern and central Nepal. China on Sunday, for the first time, opened up its devastated Gyirong County in Tibet - the site of the destroyed border immigration post - to PTI and select foreign media to show the destruction caused by the flash floods and the massive relief and reconstruction work underway.



China has been working to reconstruct roads to restore access to the cut-off border post and has sent relief materials to Nepal. According to officials'

figures on the Chinese side, 31 people were killed and 531 others remain missing in Tibet. These include 261 missing foreigners, including 49 from India and 22

from other countries. Most of the dead and missing foreigners were unlucky enough to be on both sides of the ill-fated immigration building when it was devoured by

the floods. China said, together with Nepal, it was officially determined that the August 26 disaster was caused by the collapse of a high-altitude glacier in Nepal. "We noted that experts and official institutions of China and Nepal have made a preliminary assessment of the cause of the disaster," Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jian told a media briefing in Beijing on August 28. "According to their analysis, the disaster has been triggered by a collapse of a high-altitude glacier in Nepal," he said. The glacier collapse without any warning adds a new dimension, as

experts warn that it may be one of many to come. A Chinese climate official warned that glaciers on the Tibetan Plateau are likely to become more unstable, which may lead to more collapses and cascading disasters similar to the August 26 flash floods. "Over the past 60 years, the glacier area on the Tibetan Plateau has shrunk by around 24 per cent, with around 7,000 small glaciers disappearing completely," said Gao Rong, deputy director of China's National Climate Centre, an official body of the Chinese government. "Looking ahead, the structural stability of glaciers

across the Tibetan Plateau will decline further. Glacial disasters are likely to become more frequent and could amplify in destruction and reach through cascading effects," Gao said. The Institute of Tibetan Plateau Research, Chinese Academy of Sciences, another official body, said in its report on the August 26 disaster that the mudslide created by the glacier collapse travelled 22 km along the valley and reached Gyirong Port at the Tibet border crossing in just seven minutes. Scientists stress that hazard evaluations can no longer rely solely on measuring initial collapses.



RVNL: BUILDING CONNECTIONS, CREATING POSSIBILITIES

From a railway project implementation agency to a diversified infrastructure enterprise

India's progress is reflected in the infrastructure that connects people, regions and opportunity. In little more than two decades, Rail Vikas Nigam Limited (RVNL), created to accelerate railway development, has evolved into a diversified infrastructure enterprise spanning railways, metros, bridges, tunnels, digital infrastructure, power, renewable energy and rolling stock.

EMERGING FROM A NATIONAL VISION

RVNL emerged from the National Rail Vikas Yojana announced by Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee on 15 August 2002 to strengthen railway infrastructure and accelerate capacity creation. Incorporated on 24 January 2003 under the Ministry of Railways, it received its Certificate of Commencement of Business on 18 February 2003 and began operations with its Board in 2005.

Its journey has included Category-Mini Ratna status in 2013, listing on the BSE and NSE in 2019, and Navratna status in 2023.

FROM RAIL INFRA TO ALL INFRA

RVNL's transformation is increasingly defined by its move "from Rail Infra to All Infra." Building on strengths in engineering, project management, systems integration, tunnelling, bridges and electrification, it has expanded into metros, roads and highways, ports, power and transmission, telecommunications, renewable energy and rolling-stock manufacturing.

In FY2025-26, its order book stood at approximately ₹99,262 crore, reflecting its wider infrastructure footprint.

ENGINEERING LANDMARKS

The New Pamban Bridge in Tamil Nadu represents RVNL's bridge-engineering capability, combining rail connectivity with a navigational opening for marine traffic.

The 125-km Rishikesh-Karnaprayag Rail Link is another major undertaking, involving extensive tunnelling through challenging Himalayan terrain.

RVNL has also contributed to metro projects including Indore's Yellow Line and Kolkata's Majerhat Metro Station, built over an existing railway yard and drainage canal. Its project portfolio includes the 8.86-km Vallarpadam-Idappally rail link in Kerala.

DIGITAL CONNECTIVITY AND SUSTAINABLE INFRASTRUCTURE

RVNL's participation in BharatNet's Middle-Mile Network extends its role into rural digital connectivity. Sustainability



is also becoming integral to execution through renewable energy, energy-efficient designs, recycled materials, responsible resource use and measures aimed at strengthening asset resilience.

HYDRO-IRRIGATION: A NEW FRONTIER

RVNL is expanding into hydropower and irrigation by leveraging its capabilities in large civil works, tunnelling and water conveyance.

Its assignments include the Rammam-III Hydroelectric Project for NTPC in the Teesta Basin, involving major civil and hydro-mechanical works.

In Rajasthan, RVNL is executing the Upper High-Level Canal component of the Mahi Bajaj Sagar Project through an RVNL-SCC Infrastructure joint venture. The project includes a canal and piped distribution network designed to provide irrigation to approximately 41,903 hectares.

AN EMERGING GLOBAL INFRASTRUCTURE PLAYER

RVNL's ambitions increasingly extend beyond India. Its international activities span the Middle East, Central Asia and Africa, taking Indian engineering and project-execution capability to growing infrastructure markets.

STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIPS AND TECHNOLOGY

Special Purpose Vehicles, Joint Ventures and Public-Private Partnerships have supported RVNL's expansion by combining capital, expertise and execution capability. Its partnerships now cover logistics, roads and highways, overseas ventures and rolling-stock manufacturing and maintenance, including the Vande Bharat sleeper train programme.

Technology is also becoming central to project delivery. RVNL is deploying digital project-management systems, Building Information Modelling, GIS, drone surveys, data analytics and real-time monitoring. Technology also supports smarter monitoring and maintenance across RVNL's expanding infrastructure portfolio. AI, IoT, automation and Industry 4.0 offer further

scope to improve planning, safety and productivity.

THE HUMAN CAPITAL BEHIND THE ENTERPRISE

RVNL's projects are supported by engineers, planners, project leaders, technicians and infrastructure professionals. As the company expands across sectors and international markets, future-ready talent will remain central to its growth.

SCALE, FINANCIAL STRENGTH AND FY2025-26

In FY2025-26, RVNL recorded consolidated revenue from operations of ₹20,412.12 crore and consolidated Profit After Tax of ₹870.66 crore. Its order book of approximately ₹99,262 crore provides visibility for future execution across railways, signalling, metros, ports, roads and highways, power and hydro-irrigation.

BUILDING COMMUNITIES BEYOND INFRASTRUCTURE

Infrastructure ultimately improves lives by strengthening access, connectivity and livelihoods. RVNL complements its project activity through CSR initiatives in healthcare, education, sanitation, skill development, sports promotion and community welfare.

THE NEXT TRACK

RVNL's evolution from a railway project implementation agency into a Navratna infrastructure enterprise reflects India's expanding infrastructure ambitions.

As India moves towards Viksit Bharat 2047, RVNL is combining its Indian Railways engineering heritage with diversification, technology and an expanding global outlook.

Its long-term impact will be measured not only through balance sheets, order books or kilometres built, but through regions connected, opportunities created and lives touched.

That is the larger RVNL story: building connections, creating possibilities and helping shape a more connected, capable and confident India.



RVNL

A Navratna CPSE with a distinguished legacy spanning over two decades, Rail Vikas Nigam Limited is rapidly expanding its footprint across diverse infrastructure domains, in India and around the world.

Backed by engineering excellence, timely execution and an unwavering commitment to nation-building, **RVNL** is redefining the future of integrated infrastructure.



Rishikesh Karnaprayag Project

OUR KEY VERTICALS

 Railways

 Metros

 Highways

 Bridges

 Tunnels

 Electrification

 Energy

 Hydro and Agriculture

 Buildings

 Maritime Infrastructure

 Telecommunication

 Modern Trainset Manufacturing

 Mining Infrastructure

CUTTING EDGE ENGINEERING

Precision. Speed. Resolve.



New Pamban Bridge

Vertical-Lift Railway Bridge over the sea



Rishikesh-Karnaprayag Rail Link

125-km Rail Corridor through seismic Himalayan terrain



Kolkata Metro

Driving the future of urban mobility



Uzbekistan Solar Project

Active projects across the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Maldives & Uzbekistan

PRECISION BACKED BY TECHNOLOGY



Digital Project Management System



Building Information Modelling



Drone-based surveys



3D construction techniques

CORPORATE SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY

Recognised as 'Champion of Change' and 'Impactful CSR Leader of India 2025'

Key Focus Areas



Education & skill development



Rural & community development



Women empowerment



Environment & sustainability



Sports & culture



Healthcare & well-being

SUSTAINABILITY AT THE CORE

At RVNL, sustainability is embedded into every stage of project execution, from design to delivery. Green building norms, energy-efficient systems, responsible material usage and eco-sensitive construction practices are not exceptions, they are the standard.



IRIFM

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Vande Bharat Next-Generation Sleeper Trainsets



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GST Council meet rescheduled to October 7

The GST Council meeting, originally scheduled for September 12, has been postponed to October 7 on account of the BRICS summit.

India is hosting the annual BRICS summit in New Delhi on September 12 and 13, which is expected to deliberate on a number of pressing global challenges, including the economic consequences of the West Asia crisis.

BRICS, originally comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa, expanded in 2024 to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, and the United Arab Emirates, with Indonesia joining in 2025.

Sources said in view of the BRICS summit, the 57th GST Council meeting has been rescheduled for October 7. The meeting will be preceded by an officers' meeting on October 5 and 6. (PTI)

Piyush Goyal calls for more investment in clinical trials

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Sunday called for making the pharmaceutical sector more attractive for investments in clinical trials and research and development, while urging domestic regulators to look at global practices and adopt best practices. He also suggested that the industry develop resilient supply chains and not depend on one or two geographies for necessary imports.

"I don't mind if there is an import content, which is necessary (for product development). But you have to see if it is available in many geographies or many companies, all over the world, so that no one or two countries or companies can hold a gun and hold you to ransom," he said here while addressing an event of the pharma sector. He said that depending on one country or company will hurt businesses.

On investments, Goyal said there was a need to keep an open mind and move away from a protective approach, as such practices were no longer relevant.

"We can't work with a very protective mind; those days are gone ... We have to be more inviting for investments coming to India for clinical trials, patenting their products here, for doing R&D here, for introducing new products; it needs a total reorientation of thoughts," he said. The minister asked the domestic regulators to study regulations of developed countries, take a cue from what is happening in the world.

"And look at your own regulations for more regulatory convergence with the developed world because unless our mindset and thoughts are aligned with the developed world, India cannot aim to become a developed country for 2047," he said. (PTI)

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

India's e-commerce and quick commerce platforms are gearing up for the festive season, with industry and analysts expecting healthy value growth and divergent spending trends, as strong consumer appetite for premium products co-exists alongside bargain-hunting by value-conscious shoppers.

A key growth engine in e-tailing, quick commerce's widening appeal beyond everyday groceries into fashion, electronics, and beauty is likely to gather further pace this festive season, building on the gains during the recent festival-led shopping cycles.

Shubham Nimkar, Research Analyst at Counterpoint Research, believes the festive season will be "healthy in value terms, but more measured in volume terms".

While consumers will be willing to spend, higher prices

are making them more selective, he said, with premium products in the consumer electronics segment likely to perform well, even as value-conscious consumers stay highly deal-driven.

He added that rising smartphone prices, driven by higher memory costs, could push consumers to time purchases more closely around major online sales events.

A report by research consultancy Infisum projected India's e-commerce market to nearly triple from \$125 billion in 2024 to \$345 billion by 2030, growing at a compound annual rate of 18.4 per cent and propelled by the rapid expansion of quick commerce and artificial intelligence (AI) integration.

By the end of the decade, e-commerce is expected to account for 10-12 per cent of India's retail spending and serve 420-440 million online shoppers, the report said.

Quick commerce continues to expand beyond its traditional grocery stronghold.

Devendra Meel, Chief Business Officer at Zepto, said festive shopping is becoming more diverse, with brands introducing festive-specific stock-keeping units for different occasions and regions, including smaller festivals such as Ekadashi and Teej.

Nimkar noted that consumers were increasingly comfortable using quick commerce for consumer

electronics and urgent purchases, though categories requiring discovery, assortment and price comparison would continue to favour traditional e-commerce.

Achint Setia, Chief Executive Officer of Snapdeal, said quick commerce is "largely solving for immediacy in metro India", while its non-metro consumers are shopping with intent and comparing value, viewing

US inflation, crude oil to steer bullion this week

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Upcoming US inflation figures, crude oil price movements, and geopolitical tensions in West Asia will be primary triggers for gold and silver prices, amid heightened speculation surrounding the global interest rate outlook, analysts said.

Investors will also keep an eye on consumer price data from Germany and China, GDP figures from the Eurozone, Japan and the UK, as well as China's trade data this week, they added.

"US inflation numbers would be the key trigger for bullion markets amid considerable speculation over the interest rate outlook," Pranav Mer, Senior Vice

President, EBG - Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd, said. US Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation report for August 2026 is scheduled for

release on September 11.

"In gold, the prices look for resistance at ₹1.57 lakh per 10 grams, while in case of silver we still maintain a positive bias till prices are

above supports at ₹2.31 lakh per kg," Pranav Mer, Senior Vice President, EBG - Commodity & Currency Research, JM Financial Services Ltd, said.

Last week, gold futures for October delivery fell ₹3,514, or 2.2 per cent, to ₹1.52 lakh per 10 grams, while silver declined ₹4,786, or nearly 2 per cent, to ₹2.37 lakh per kg on the Multi Commodity Exchange.

"MCX gold witnessed volatile moves this week, with the first half seeing continued profit booking following last Friday's correction after the Fed indicated the possibility of a rate hike," Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said.

the two formats as serving different occasions rather than directly competing.

"Value-seeking remains the dominant behaviour for the consumer we serve. Our buyer is looking for quality at the right price, not a brand premium. That said, 'value' doesn't mean the cheapest possible option.

"We're seeing consumers trade up within their budget, upgrading to better quality or more aspirational products, as long as the price stays sensible. It's aspiration within a value frame, not premiumisation in the way it plays out for metro, brand-led shoppers," he said.

Non-metro India continues to be described as central to festive demand.

Setia said more than 80 per cent of Snapdeal's sales came from non-metro regions. A Meesho spokesperson said 73 per cent of the platform's orders during Rakhi came from non-metro markets, with seller participation up 72 per cent year-on-

year. The Infisum report also found that 66 per cent of new D2C orders now originate from Tier II and Tier III cities.

AI-native retail technology company Fynd's Chief Business Officer Ragini Varma said the festive demand window is shifting earlier, rather than simply becoming more concentrated around Diwali.

"Fynd's data shows that pre-Navratri D2C order volumes were already up 16 per cent year-on-year in August 2025, making the pre-season an increasingly important selling window.

"In 2025, D2C GMV around Diwali grew 47 per cent year-on-year, compared with 34 per cent in 2024. For 2026, our expectation is that this earlier demand pattern will continue, with D2C Diwali GMV growth projected at 35-40 per cent," she said.

Artificial intelligence was flagged repeatedly as a growing influence on shopping behaviour.

Government plans wider FDI in plantation sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

The Government is considering liberalising foreign direct investment (FDI) norms in the plantation sector by bringing more commercial crops under the ambit, an official said. The Commerce and Industry Ministry is holding stakeholder consultations on the issue, the official said.

"We are looking for more FDI liberalisation in the plantation sector like banana," the official added.

At present, 100 per cent FDI under the automatic route is permitted in the tea sector, including tea plantations, coffee, rubber, cardamom, and palm and olive oil tree plantations.

Besides these, FDI is not allowed in any other plantation sector/activity.

India has received \$295.23 million FDI in tea and coffee (processing and warehousing coffee), and \$3.93 billion in rubber goods during April 2000 and March 2026.

As per estimates, India is the largest banana producer in the world with over 30 million tonnes annually.

SBI to hire 12,000, add 250 branches during FY27, says Chairman Setty

KUMAR DIPANKAR ■ New Delhi

State Bank of India (SBI) intends to hire about 12,000 personnel and add around 250 new branches to its network in the ongoing financial year, said CS Setty, Chairman of the country's biggest lender.

"In terms of recruitment, I think we would be looking at around 11,000 to 12,000 appointments across both clerical and officer cadres this year. This number may vary depending on retirements and emerging requirements, but I expect we should close the year with around 12,000 recruitments," he told PTI in an interaction.

"Last year, we have done fairly large recruitment because we took 1,500 specialist IT officers. This year, we do not need such a large number on the IT (information technology) side," he said. With a workforce of over 2.45 lakh employees as of March 2026, SBI is among India's largest employers.

SBI has hired 4,640 officers, 19,340 associates, and 1,653 contractual staff in 2025-26, taking the total number of hires to 25,633, as per the bank's annual report for FY26.

On the branch expansion side, Setty said that, despite having a large network, there is still some white space in many areas; whether new



colonies are coming up or even in commercially active districts, the bank's presence can be improved.

"We also are looking at rationalisation of some of the branches, which means that our number broadly will be growing by maybe 200 to 250 per year on the net side," he said.

About stake dilution in the National Stock Exchange (NSE), Setty said, SBI and its subsidiary SBI Capital Markets Ltd together plan to dilute up to 1 per cent stake through the exchange's proposed Rs 30,000-crore initial public offering (IPO).

"We are participating in that divestment. We propose to divest 0.65 per cent and 0.35 per cent by SBI Capital

Markets because both of us hold the stake. So together, about 1 per cent as an SBI group... it could be less depending on any other shareholders joining," he said.

SBI currently holds a 3.23 per cent stake in the NSE, while SBI Capital Markets owns 4.33 per cent in the country's largest stock exchange. Last week, NSE received regulatory approval for the long-awaited ₹30,000-crore initial public offering (IPO), which could potentially be the country's biggest-ever yet.

The NSE IPO will surpass Hyundai Motor India's ₹27,858.75-crore listing in 2024 as well as LIC of India's ₹20,557.23-crore offering in 2022. It will also dwarf Paytm's

(One97 Communications) ₹18,300-crore (2021), Tata Capital's ₹15,511.87-crore (2025) and Coal India's ₹15,200-crore (2010) listing.

He clarified that there is no monetisation plan for other subsidiaries in the immediate future. In July, SBI, along with its foreign partner Paris-headquartered Amundi, diluted around a 10 per cent stake in SBI Mutual Fund, including pre IPO. The ₹11,675-crore monetisation by the country's biggest fund house was a huge success as the issue was subscribed 41.66 times.

Post-listing, SBI's holding declined to 55.56 per cent from 61.86 per cent, while Amundi's stake reduced to 32.63 per cent, down 3.7 per cent. (PTI)

Indian Bank to open representative office in Dubai to expand foreign operations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chennai

Indian Bank has received board approval to open a representative office in Dubai, as it seeks to expand its overseas operations, leveraging the large Indian diaspora across West Asia. Currently, the bank has a full-service international branch in Singapore and branches in Colombo and Jaffna (Sri Lanka). Besides, it has an IFSC Banking Unit (IBU) functioning as an off-shore/foreign branch from GIFT City, Gandhinagar.

"We are getting good business from our GIFT City branch, including participation in various syndicated loans...my aim now is to open a rep office in Dubai..We have a good number of non-resident Indians settled in Dubai and about 33 per cent of the working population is Indian," Indian Bank MD and CEO Binod Kumar told PTI in an interaction.

For the representative office in Dubai, the bank's board has given its approval and the bank is in the process of seeking other regulatory approvals.

Besides, Kumar said, the bank is exploring the possibility of having a presence in Malaysia and



Indonesia. On the domestic side, he said, Indian Bank plans to add 100 branches this year with a primary focus on increasing the bank's presence in the central and western parts of the country.

To manage growing business needs and replace retiring employees, the bank would increase its headcount by about 2,500 personnel, including specialist officers. "Last year, we opened 100 branches. This year too, we have similar plans. Just on August 15, which was our foundation day, the bank inaugurated 15 branches across the country," he said.

The bank had 6,003 domestic branches as of June 30, 2026. The seventh-biggest public sector bank enhanced its presence in the eastern region and Uttar Pradesh with the amalgamation of Allahabad Bank in 2020.

Difficult time for microfinance business behind us, Q2 to see growth: IndusInd Bank MD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The difficult phase for the micro-finance business is now behind us, with risks playing out favourably, and growth in the segment is expected to return from the second quarter onwards, IndusInd Bank MD and CEO Rajiv Anand has said. IndusInd Bank faced a severe governance and accounting crisis in 2025 centred around its microfinance subsidiary, Bharat Financial Inclusion Ltd (BFIL). The bank reversed ₹674 crore of cumulative interest income recognised incorrectly across FY25. A further ₹172 crore was disclosed as fraud, where employees falsely reported the sum as fee income in the micro-finance business.

"We have had a fairly difficult time on our microfinance business. But it is all now behind us. Risk is playing out quite well at this point in time and Q2 onwards we should see growth come back in our microfinance businesses," Anand said in an interview. The microfinance arm has a very successful business called Bharat Superstore, where it lends to kirana stores, small restaurants and other such businesses, he said.

"That business is also doing well and continues to perform strongly. So, the entire micro-finance and rural banking business that we have should



IndusInd Bank MD and CEO Rajiv Anand

show strong growth as we move into the second quarter and beyond," he added. "We needed to scale up our disbursements, which has now happened, and we are very confident that we should see growth from here," he said.

Asked about growth in microfinance portfolio in FY27, Anand said, "We think that this year, our microfinance business should grow somewhere between 15-20 per cent". On the overall asset side, he said the growth will be broadly in line with the market for the current financial year.

"Whatever the market is, I think currently the market is around 17-18 per cent. We believe we will be in that vicinity," he said. About the impact of Expected Credit Loss (ECL) guidelines coming into force from April 1, 2027, Anand said, "We would require around 1-1.5 per cent of assets. At least, that's our first estimate. Our net worth is more than adequate to absorb the impact".

Amitabh Shrivastav's Shivohum 2.0 explores oneness and interconnectedness

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Visual artist Amitabh Shrivastav's solo exhibition, "Shivohum 2.0 — The Unification," is being held from September 2 to 7, 2026, at Jehangir Art Gallery in Mumbai. The exhibition explores themes of coexistence, oneness in duality and interconnectedness through a visual language centred on red, black and their dynamic interplay.

The exhibition features acrylic paintings on canvas, along with an installation made using vetiver roots. Through his works, Shrivastav examines the meeting of seemingly contradictory forces and the possibility of finding unity within their coexistence.

A graduate in Fine Arts from Banaras Hindu University and a PhD in Art & Design from Sorbonne,



France, Shrivastav has developed a multidisciplinary artistic practice spanning painting, sculpture, mixed-media installation, AI-Robotics and public art. His practice brings together ecological, philosophical and spiritual thought with contemporary artistic processes, exploring the relationship between human existence and the natural world.

Vetiver Roots as a Metaphor for Interconnectedness

In Shivohum 2.0: The Unification, Dr. Shrivastav draws inspiration from the intricate structures of vetiver

roots (Chrysopogon zizanioides) and their ecological intelligence.

Known for their deep-reaching root systems that hold soil, conserve groundwater and participate in networks of natural exchange, vetiver becomes a metaphor for interconnected existence in the artist's work.

The organic complexity of the roots informs his visual vocabulary, with branching forms, rhythmic movements and enveloping voids evoking bodily structures, circulation, memory and the womb as a site of creation.

ALIMCO-Honda India Foundation partnership strengthens assistive-device access

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Manesar

Emphasising the need for a whole-of-society approach towards building an inclusive and accessible India, Ms Manmeet Kaur Nanda, Additional Secretary, Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPWD), Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment, inaugurated the Pradhan Mantri Divyasha-Vayoshri Kendra (PMDVK) at Honda Samajik Vikas Kendra, Naurangpur, Manesar, on Wednesday.

The new PMDVK has been



established through the partnership between the Artificial Limbs Manufacturing Corporation of India (ALIMCO) and Honda India Foundation. The centre

aims to strengthen access to assistive devices, assessment, rehabilitation and related services for persons with disabilities and senior citizens.

Addressing the gathering, Ms Nanda appreciated the ten-year partnership between ALIMCO and Honda India Foundation.

She described the new, larger and better-equipped centre as a strong example of Government-corporate collaboration through Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR).

She emphasised that while Government schemes provide reach and scale, partnerships with corporates, NGOs, civil society and industry bring innovation, depth and last-mile connect. She also called upon all

stakeholders to contribute towards building a "Sugamya Viksit Bharat."

Ms Nanda highlighted the significance of 2026, which marks ten years of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016, as well as twenty years of India's association with the UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities.

Focus on Last-Mile Delivery
Shri Praveen Kumar, CMD, ALIMCO, underscored the importance of the organisation's long-standing association with Honda India Foundation.

Food processing sector eyes 30% level, \$500B growth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India's food processing industry is gearing up for its next phase of growth, with the sector aiming to raise its processing level from the current 16-17 per cent to as much as 30 per cent.

Industry leaders say rising demand for healthier and premium foods, greater formalisation, infrastructure upgrades, advanced technology and automation will be critical to making Indian food products more globally competitive.

The proposed India-EU Free Trade Agreement is also expected to open new opportunities, with bilateral agri-food trade potentially doubling to \$110 billion by 2032. The outlook was discussed at a precursor event in New Delhi ahead of Anuga Select India 2026 and



Anuga FoodTec India 2026, which will bring global food, beverage and food-processing companies together in Mumbai later this month.

India's Food Processing Sector Eyes 30 per cent Processing Level as Trade and Technology Drive \$500-Billion Growth India's food processing industry is gearing up for its next phase of growth, with the sector aiming to raise its processing level from the current 16-17 per cent to as much as 30 per cent.

France's first traditional Hindu Mandir consecrated in Paris

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE/AGENCIES ■ Paris/Bussy-Saint-Georges

France's first traditional Hindu mandir was officially inaugurated in Paris on Sunday following a grand murti-pratishtha (consecration) ceremony led by His Holiness Mahant Swami Maharaj, spiritual leader of BAPS Swaminarayan Sanstha.

The historic ceremony marked the conclusion of a 13-day inaugural festival that brought together swamis, devotees and distinguished dignitaries from across Europe, North America, Africa, Australia and Asia. Visitors and delegates from more than 40 countries, including India, the United States, Canada, Africa, Australia and England, participated in the celebrations.

Earlier in the morning, amid the chanting of sacred Vedic verses, the auspicious murti-pratishtha rituals were performed by Mahant Swami Maharaj. The ceremony saw the consecration of the sacred murtis of Shri Akshar-Purushottam Maharaj, Shri Ghanshyam Maharaj, Shri Radha-Krishna Bhagwan, Shri Sita-Ram Bhagwan with Shri Lakshmanji and Shri Hanumanji Maharaj, Shri Parvati-Shankar Bhagwan with Shri Kartikeyaji and Shri Ganeshiji Maharaj, Shri Padmavati Venkateshwar Bhagwan, Shri Ayyappa Swamiji, Shri Nilkanth Varni Maharaj, the form of Bhagwan Swaminarayan, and the Guru Parampara.

Following the consecration, Mahant Swami Maharaj offered the first prayer at the temple for the preservation of mutual love and harmony among all religions, global peace and the well-being of all.

Historic Nagar Yatra in Paris
Ahead of the consecration



ceremony, a grand Nagar Yatra was organised through the streets of Paris, showcasing Indian music, art and devotional traditions.

The procession featured 14 beautifully decorated floats, along with dancers dressed in traditional costumes. The adorned murtis, representing the divine forms of Hindu deities, were taken along prominent routes through the French capital.

The Nagar Yatra passed landmarks including the world-renowned Eiffel Tower and École Militaire before culminating at Place de la Concorde. The spiritual procession marked a new chapter for the celebration of Indian culture and Hinduism in France, with a message of love and harmony.

A Blend of Traditional Indian Architecture and French Engineering. The newly constructed mandir has been built in accordance with ancient Indian architecture and traditional Vedic Shilpashastras, while also integrating modern French engineering and building techniques.

The mandir is spread across 5,000 square metres. Its upper level houses the traditional mandir, while a beautiful Haveli at its base serves as a cultural centre. Marble sourced from India, Italy, Greece and Vietnam, along with Gwalior sandstone, has been used in

the construction.

The structure features five shikhars, 10 large domes, 20 carved pillars, 120 gavakshas, 49 sculpted charitra figures and four decorated chhatris. The mandir complex also includes an assembly hall, classrooms, a sports room, exhibition space and offices.

A Vision Spanning More Than Five Decades

The vision for constructing a grand mandir in Paris was first pledged by Guru Yogiji Maharaj in 1970. His successor, Pramukh Swami Maharaj, nurtured the vision during his spiritual visits abroad and helped establish the foundation of satsang in France. The Bhumi Pujan ceremony for the mandir was performed in 2021 in the presence of senior swamis, followed by the Shilanyas ceremony in 2022. Construction of the mandir was completed in 2026.

A Centre for Indian Culture and Universal Well-being

Established on French soil, the first traditional Hindu mandir in France is intended to serve as a medium for introducing people across the globe to Indian culture and traditions.

The mandir is also envisioned as a living symbol of worship, love, harmony and unity. Through its spiritual and cultural activities, it will continue to share a message of global well-being and mutual harmony.

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NOTICE CONVENING 46TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, BOOK CLOSURE AND E-VOTING INFORMATION

In continuation to our newspaper advertisement dated September 03, 2026 Notice is hereby given that **Forty-sixth (46th) Annual General Meeting ("AGM")** of the members of **Orissa Sponge Iron & Steel Limited ("the Company")** will be held on **Wednesday, September 30, 2026, at 03:00 P.M.**, through Video Conferencing/other audio visual means (VC/OAVM) only without physical presence of the members at the venue, in compliance with all the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ("the Act") and the Rules made thereunder read with General Circular No. 20/2020 dated 5th May, 2020, 9/2023 dated 25th September, 2023 and 9/2024 dated 19th September, 2024 issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) read with SEBI Circular dated 7th October, 2023 (collectively referred to as *Circulars*) to transact the business as set out in the Notice of the AGM. The registered office of the Company shall be the deemed venue of the Meeting. In terms of the said MCA Circulars, the Notice of the 46th AGM along with the Annual Report 2025-26 including financial statements for the financial year 2025-26 along with Board's Report, Auditor's Report and other documents required to be attached thereto, have been sent on Saturday, September 05, 2026 through electronic mode has sent only to those Members whose e-mail addresses are registered with the Company or Registrar & Share Transfer Agent (RTA) or Depository Participants (DP). The requirement of sending physical copies of the Notice of the AGM has been dispensed with, vide MCA Circulars. However, hard copy of AGM documents will be sent to those members who specifically request for the same. In respect to the receipt of hard copy of Annual Report for 2025-26, members are requested to drop an email to Corporate@Orissaspange.com duly quoted their folio No./ DP ID/ client ID. The Annual Report 2025-26 of the Company, inter-alia, contains the Notice of the 46th AGM is also available on the website of the Company at www.orissaspange.com and on the website of National Securities Depository Limited ("NSDL") at www.evoting.nsdl.com. Further, Members may directly access the Annual Report for FY 2025-26 at the following link-<https://orissaspange.com/docs/Annual%20Report%202025-26.pdf> Remote E-Voting and joining AGM through VC/OAVM: In compliance with Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, as amended from time to time, the Secretarial Standard on General Meetings (SS-2) issued by the Institute of Company Secretaries of India, the Company is providing to its Members the facility of remote e-Voting before as well as during the AGM in respect of the business to be transacted at the AGM and for this purpose, the Company has appointed NSDL for facilitating voting through electronic means. The detailed instructions for remote e-Voting and joining AGM are given in the Notice of the AGM. Members are requested to note the following:

- The remote e-Voting will commence from 09:00 A.M. (IST) on Saturday, September 26, 2026 and ends at 05:00 P.M. (IST) on Tuesday, September 29, 2026. The remote e-Voting module shall be disabled thereafter by NSDL for voting.
- The voting rights of the Members shall be in proportion to their share of the paid-up capital of the Company as on Thursday, September 24, 2026 ("Cut-off" date).
- The facility of remote e-Voting system shall also be made available during the AGM and the Members attending the Meeting, who have not already cast their vote by remote e-Voting shall be able to exercise their right during the Meeting. A person whose name is recorded in the Registrar of Members/ Register of Beneficial Owners as on the Cut-Off date shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-Voting before/during the AGM.
- Any person who acquires shares of the Company and becomes a Member of the Company after the date of the Notice and holds shares as on the Cut-Off date, may obtain the login-id and password for remote e-Voting by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.com, or may contact on toll free number 022-48867000 as provided by NSDL. A person who is not a member as on the Cut-Off date should treat the Notice of the AGM for information purpose only.
- The notice of AGM inter-alia includes the process and manner of remote e-voting/e-voting and instructions for participation in the AGM.
- Members who have cast their vote by remote e-Voting prior to the meeting may also attend the meeting electronically, but shall not be entitled to vote again.
- The same login credentials for e-Voting, may also be used for attending the AGM through VC/OAVM.
- The Company has appointed Mr. Neeraj Jain, Practising Company Secretary (Membership No. FCS 9599, COP No. 26163), Proprietor of M/s. Neeraj Jain & Associates, Company Secretaries, to act as the Scrutinizer for conducting the e-voting process in a fair and transparent manner. The Scrutinizer will submit his report to the Chairman / or a person as may be authorized by the Chairman, within 48 hours of the conclusion of AGM. The voting results of the voting conducted for 46th AGM along with scrutinizer's Report will be made available on the website of the Company at www.orissaspange.com and on the website of NSDL at www.evoting.nsdl.com.

Any person who acquires shares and become member of the Company after dispatch of notice and holding shares as on **cut-off date** i.e. Thursday, 24th September, 2026 may obtain login id and password by sending a request over email at evoting@nsdl.com mentioning demat account number/folio number, PAN, name and registered address. However, Members who are already registered with NSDL for e-voting can use their existing User id and Password for casting their vote through remote e-voting/e-voting at the AGM. Manner of voting for members holding shares in physical form, dematerialized form or who have not registered their e-mail address with the Company is provided in the Notice of AGM, which is also available on the website of the Company at <https://orissaspange.com/docs/46th%20AGM%20Notice.pdf>

The results shall be declared not later than 48 hours from conclusion of the meeting by posting the same on the website of the Company at www.orissaspange.com and website of NSDL, www.evoting.nsdl.com. It shall also be displayed on the Notice Board at the Registered Office & Corporate Office of the Company. Subject to the requisite number of votes, the Resolutions shall be deemed to be passed on the date of the AGM i.e. 30th September, 2026.

REGISTRATION OF E-MAIL ADDRESS: Members who have not yet registered their e-mail addresses are requested to register their email address. Member holding shares in demat form are requested to update the same with their Depository Participant or to Skyline Financial Services Private Limited ("RTA") for members holding shares in physical form.

In case of any queries, grievances connected with remote e-Voting, you may refer to the Frequently Asked Questions and e-Voting user manual for shareholders available at the "Downloads" section of www.evoting.nsdl.com or call on toll free no.: 022-48867000 or send a request to Ms. Pallavi Mhatre, Senior Manager at evoting@nsdl.com. Further, the shareholders may also write to Mr. Suraj Kumar Thakur, Company Secretary at email ID corporate@orissaspange.com. The members are requested to carefully read all the notes set out in the notice of 46th AGM and in particular, instructions for joining AGM through VC/OAVM, manner of casting vote through remote e-voting.

BOOK CLOSURE: Notice is hereby given that pursuant to Section 91 of the Act and rules framed thereunder, the register of members and the Share Transfer Books of the Company will remain closed from 24th September, 2026 to 30th September, 2026 (both days inclusive) for the purpose of holding 46th AGM.

For Orissa Sponge Iron and Steel Limited

Sd/-
Suraj Thakur
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer

Place: New Delhi

Date: 06.09.2026

Indira Gandhi Delhi Technical University For Women
(Established by Govt. of Delhi vide Act 09 of 2012)
Kashmere Gate, Delhi-110006

DEPARTMENT OF MANAGEMENT
BBA ADMISSIONS 2026-27
SPECIAL SPOT ROUND: 10th SEPTEMBER 2026

Fresh registrations are invited for the Special Spot Round of admission to the BBA Program to be held on **10.09.2026 at IGDTUW.**

Eligibility: A Female candidate who has scored at least 50% marks in 12th board examination from a recognized board and must also have passed English (Core /Elective/Functional) as a subject in the 12th Board Examination.

For registration, detailed schedule and other information, please visit www.igdtuw.ac.in or <http://cmacadmissions.com/bba>

REGISTRAR, IGDTUW

DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0199/26-27

BRIEFLY

Qinwen makes US Open comeback, Naomi joins her in fourth round



Zheng Qinwen was on her back with her arms in the air, celebrating a U.S. Open victory maybe only she believed was possible. Madison Keys fought off tears as she tried to explain how Zheng, way down and all but out, somehow got the win. Zheng, the Olympic gold medalist, extended her return to the U.S. Open on Saturday with a spectacular and stunning rally, winning the final seven games to eliminate No. 22 Keys 1-6, 7-6 (3), 7-5.

"I feel like I obviously got off to a really good lead, and then I just got really - I mean, got really scared, like I couldn't swing," Keys said. "I don't know. Tennis just feels really hard right now, so I feel like that kind of took over." Hours later, 13th-seeded Naomi Osaka joined her in the fourth round by defeating Elise Mertens 6-3, 3-6, 7-5. The two-time champion from Japan put her head on her racket after the final point, stunned herself at the victory. "Honestly, I can't believe I won this match," Osaka said. "I'm literally shocked that I won this match."

Not quite as big a comeback as Zheng, but Osaka was down 4-2 in the third set and apologized for expressing so much frustration throughout a tough night. "There was a certain point, I don't know, I felt like I put my entire heart on the court and then I just kept trying every single point," Osaka said. "I didn't feel like I played amazing, and it was really getting me down. I was very negative on myself." Osaka avoided the kind of exit men's No. 9 seed Taylor Fritz endured, blowing a two-set lead and falling to No. 24 Francisco Cerundolo 3-6, 4-6, 6-3, 6-4, 6-4. "I don't know how I let that happen today," Fritz said.

Amanda Anisimova, like Fritz and Keys a past runner-up at the U.S. Open, also was knocked out when the No. 10 seed lost to No. 24 Anastasia Potapova 6-2, 7-5. No. 5 Flavio Cobolli, the French Open runner-up, lost in four sets to No. 28 Alexander Blockx to leave the men's draw without six of the top 10 seeds. Keys won a three-set match in the previous round in a match tiebreaker when she fought off five match points. Two days later came a collapse that was as out-of-nowhere as that comeback.

The 2017 runner-up rebounded after losing the second-set tiebreaker to charge out to a 5-0 lead. Zheng held but Keys had a match point while serving at 5-1, and once she couldn't convert that, the turnaround was on, with Keys at one point banging her racket into her head repeatedly and pulling off her visor in disgust. "I'm just telling myself keep holding every single point, never give up, stay there and somehow little by little it just happened," Zheng said.

She won the gold medal for China at the 2024 Olympics after reaching the Australian Open final that year, and has been ranked as high as No. 4. But after elbow surgery, she is down to No. 121 and had to go through qualifying just to make the main draw. "The hard work pays off," said Zheng, who will play 2022 U.S. Open champion Iga Swiatek next. Coco Gauff, the 2023 U.S. Open champion, beat Cristina Bucsa 6-3, 6-4. She'll face 18-year-old Iva Jovic in a matchup of young Americans with a spot in quarterfinals on line. (AP)

Satwik-Chirag clinch China Masters title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Shenzhen

Star Indian men's doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty produced a stirring comeback to beat China's He Ji Ting and Ren Xiang Yu in a three-game thriller and clinch the China Masters Super 750 title here on Sunday.

Playing their third final here, Satwik and Chirag, who finished runners-up in the 2023 and 2025 editions, fought their way to an 11-21-13 21-17 victory over former world No. 4 He and Ren in a one-hour and 10-minute battle. It is the second title of the season for the Indians, who had won the Singapore

Open Super 750 and also reached the final of the Thailand Open Super 500.

The title is a big boost for the world No. 5 pair as they gear up to defend their gold medal at the Asian Games, scheduled to be held in Japan from September 19.

The Indians were up against a Chinese pair whose ranking had slipped to world No. 70 following a prolonged absence from the circuit.

It is just the third event for He Ji Ting, who returned to competitive badminton after serving a team-imposed disciplinary suspension by the Chinese Badminton Association (CBA).

Satwik and Chirag, however, had defeated the



Chinese pair twice in their only two previous meetings.

The Indian pair had played three three-game matches en route to the final, dropping the second game after winning the opening game in each of those encounters.

Playing their third final in their 10th tournament of the year, Satwik and Chirag opted to choose ends after winning the toss instead of receiving.

The Indians couldn't take early control of the rallies as He Ji Ting and Ren zoomed to

a 5-0 lead with fast, attacking strokes in short and snappy exchanges. They kept their serves tight and flat while maintaining an angled attack. A jump smash from He Ji Ting helped the Chinese pair maintain their five-point lead at 8-3.

The Indians tried to break through their rivals' defence, but the fast and aggressive Chinese pair took a six-point advantage into the interval. The Indians couldn't quite match the pace of their rivals as the deficit widened to 7-14. He Ji Ting looked in ominous touch, raining down thunderous smashes to shatter the Indians' defence.

A service fault from Chirag only added to the agony as

the Chinese pair stretched their lead to 17-9. Another wide shot from Chirag allowed the Chinese pair to wrap up the opening game.

The Indians produced a far better show in the second game, tightening their defence and extending the rallies. Satwik also opted for a flick serve to keep the Chinese pair guessing and prevented them from engaging in the front court too often.

Satwik and Chirag wrested the lead at 7-6 after a closely fought passage of play. A body smash from Chirag, their fifth straight point, took the Indians to 9-6, but a service error from Satwik ended their run.

Russell aims to trim Antonelli's F1 lead at Italian GP

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Monza (Italy)

George Russell will be looking to make up some ground on Kimi Antonelli in the Formula 1 title race, with his Mercedes teammate starting from the back of the grid at the Italian Grand Prix.

But he will start second, behind surprise polesitter Pierre Gasly, who stunned everyone by snatching top spot for the first time in qualifying on Saturday.

Russell will also have both Ferrari cars breathing down his neck as Charles Leclerc and Lewis Hamilton fill out the second row in the scud-



eria's home race, where they will be cheered on by the

hordes of passionate, red-clad tifosi. Russell is second

in the overall standings, level with Hamilton and 59 points behind Antonelli, who is bidding to become F1's youngest champion.

The 20-year-old Antonelli has taken on a hefty grid penalty at Monza after Mercedes opted to swap his car's power unit to head off potential reliability problems in the second half of the season. Lando Norris is hoping to make it a hat trick of victories to turbocharge his title defense but he starts in eighth. The McLaren driver triumphed in Hungary and the Netherlands to cut the gap to Antonelli to 83 points.

Katie Taylor wins farewell fight at Croke Park

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Dublin

Katie Taylor closed out her remarkable career with a dominant victory over previously undefeated Flora Pili in front of 80,000 fans at Croke Park on Saturday.

The Irish boxer who won an Olympic gold medal and headlined at Madison Square Garden got her final career wish - to fight at Ireland's sporting cathedral. The 40-year-old Taylor dominated her French opponent over 10

rounds for a unanimous decision victory to retire as the undisputed champion at 140 pounds. Taylor (26-1) added the vacant WBC super lightweight title to her WBO, WBA and IBF belts. The judges' scores were 100-90, 100-90 and 98-91. Pili's record is 12-1 with the loss. In April 2022, Taylor beat Amanda Serrano at a sold-out Madison Square Garden in what was the first women's boxing match to headline the arena. The pair have fought three times in total,



with Taylor victorious each time, most recently in 2025. Taylor won gold at the 2012 London Games. Muhammad

Ali touched down in the Emerald Isle in July 1972 for a 12-round non-title fight against Alvin "Blue" Lewis.

DAILY SUDOKU

			8				4
			3			5	
2	7		5		9	3	
		2		3	1		
3		1			7		9
	4		8		5		
7	8			3		2	5
	9			8			
5			6				

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.

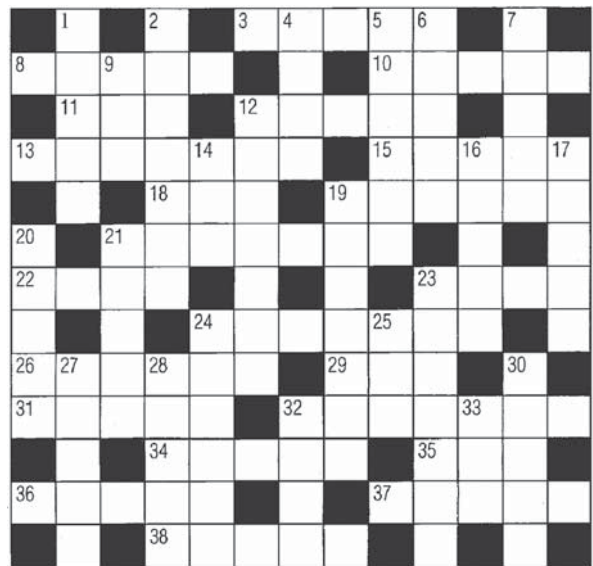
SOLUTION (5.9.26)

9	8	5	7	3	2	6	4	1
2	4	6	5	1	8	9	7	3
3	1	7	9	6	4	5	8	2
8	7	1	4	2	6	3	5	9
4	6	3	1	5	9	7	2	8
5	2	9	3	8	7	1	6	4
6	5	4	8	9	1	2	3	7
7	9	2	6	4	3	8	1	5
1	3	8	2	7	5	4	9	6

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DOUBLE CROSSWORD

MONDAY | SEPTEMBER 7, 2026



ACROSS

- In Formula 1, he was in favour of finishing fast (5)
- In Birmingham, a street ahead (5)
- A dirty globe? (5)
- Teacher is backward at any one of the three Rs! (3)
- Having half a mind service has been cut, he won't pay (5)
- Such clothing fits Una badly (7)
- A pie's possibly a nice warm colour (5)
- Tommy's tosh? (3)
- The hard facts one may get back to (6)
- A land we reunited in Anglo-Saxon England (7)

DOWN

- Children may be the outcome (5)
- Depict badly in ropy art (7)
- I ran out in the wet (4)
- You'll observe, now and then, that it balances (6)
- Plants grown by sailors out East? (5)
- One philosophical about the cost of straying out of line? (5)
- Briefly, it's positively assertive (3)
- Sailor meaning a great deal to his friend (7)
- A little matter one gets ahead with (3)
- A paid player (5)

- Light, first-class railway (4)
- Did Leander love to give her a ring? (4)
- Fatherly musical celebrity? (3,4)
- Stake about everything in a stage production (6)
- That woman absorbed in motherhood
- It makes an admission (5)
- Space for manoeuvre in a ship's cabin? (3,4)
- A hero, but to many a libertine (5)
- Sick of villainy and pillage (3)
- Allow to pass to leg, perhaps (3,2)
- In betting, a borderline thing? (5)
- Oldster led astray by a bit of a youngster? (5)

- First lady to be seated, in a sense (5)
- Wailing woman has been confused (7)
- Two bachelors, one Disney character (5)
- Soldiers may find it boring (5)
- Just the aircraft to worry the enemy (7)
- Something filling you can get at the station (6)
- Dried leaves (3)
- Strong resentment of a bit of a clanger (5)
- Left on the side of a shelf (5)
- Victor taking a girl on the river (5)
- Where to get some whisky, etc. (4)
- New opposition (3)

Junior Asia Cup hockey: India rally to draw with Japan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Moqi (China)

The Indian junior men's hockey team showed tremendous grit to rally and secure a 3-3 draw against Japan in their second Pool A match of the Junior Asia Cup here on Sunday.

Fresh from their emphatic 14-0 victory over Indonesia in their opening pool match, India took the lead in the fourth minute through a penalty stroke following a foul. Captain Anmol Ekka stepped up and calmly converted to put India 1-0 ahead.

India continued to build pressure and doubled their advantage in the 10th minute through a penalty corner conversion by Ashu Maurya. Japan responded almost immediately, winning a penalty corner in the 11th minute. Ryushin Sasaki converted the opportunity to pull one goal back and make it 2-1.

Both teams continued to push forward in the second quarter, with India looking to extend their lead and Japan searching for the equaliser. The contest remained tightly fought, with both defences holding



firm. Neither side was able to create the decisive opening, and India went into the half-time break leading 2-1.

The third quarter followed a similar pattern, with both teams battling hard for control. Japan created some good opportunities and earned a penalty corner but were unable to convert it, while India's defence continued to protect their narrow advantage.

The final quarter saw the intensity rise as Japan pressed for an equaliser. Japan won a penalty corner and, after a rewarded penalty corner,

captain Kazuki Nakanishi converted in the 48th minute to level the score at 2-2.

Japan continued to threaten in the closing stages and earned another penalty corner in the final five minutes. India defended the initial attempt well but were unable to clear the ball, resulting in another penalty corner for Japan. This time, Japan's flick went wide.

With time ticking away, Japan won another penalty corner and Nakanishi stepped up once again, finding the target with a flick in the 59th minute to put Japan ahead 3-2.

Indian women's team thrashes Malaysia in AHF Junior Asia Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Moqi (China)

Indian women's team consolidated its position at the top of the points table with an 11-1 hammering of Malaysia in their AHF Junior Asia Cup Elite Pool match here on Sunday.

India had as many as seven different players scoring against Malaysia after the team made a winning start to the campaign, defeating South Korea 4-1 in the tournament opener. Against Malaysia, the Indian players scored four goals from field play, five from penalty corners and two from penalty strokes. Puja Sahoo opened the



scoring for India in the first minute through a penalty stroke, and the advantage was doubled in the fourth when Purnima Yadav found the back of the net.

Defending champions India continued to build on their advantage as Binima Dhan

converted a penalty corner in the eighth minute before Krishna Sharma added another in the 14th.

In the second quarter, Purnima completed her brace in the 17th minute from a penalty corner, while two more goals came before half-time.

Duleep Trophy final: Kishan’s hundred leads East’s run glut on Day 1

G UNNIKRIISHNAN
■ Chennai

Skipper Ishan Kishan struck a flowing unbeaten 111, leading East Zone to a commanding 385 for four against a sloppy South Zone on the opening day of the Duleep Trophy final here on Sunday.

Kishan (14x4, 1x6) and Kumar Kushagra (63) were batting at stumps, and the fifth wicket pair has so far added 144 runs in just 26.4 overs.

The other contributors were teen phenom Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (44, 37b), Abhimanyu Easwaran (72), and Shikhar Mohan (85).

Kishan, who completed 4000 first-class runs, merged

aggression and composure to a nicety in his 135-ball knock, and raised 94 runs for the fourth wicket with Mohan.

It came at an important juncture too when East were in trouble, the only time in the first innings so far, at 147 for three.

South could have had their rivals in a far deeper predicament but Kishan and Mohan averted the disaster on a pitch that remained true the whole day.

Kishan’s was a complete innings, sending the ball to all parts of the field through powerful pulls and imperious drives through the covers.

The left-hander reached his fifty in 71 balls and then the next 50 came off 51 balls,



completing his 10th first-class hundred.

Kishan reached the landmark with a driven four off Shreyas Gopal, who was playing in his 100th first-class match.

At the other end, Mohan has a solid presence, showing a lot more maturity than his tender 21 years.

The feature of his innings was the judgment he showed to leave the ball outside off-stump. There was not even one single play and miss in his innings.

But his fifty was not all about defence as Mohan carted off-spinner Tripurana Vijay for a six and two fours in one over to showcase his range.

Just as he was nearing a well-deserved hundred, Mohan chopped left-arm pacer CV Milind, who replaced an injured Vidwath Kaverappa, on to his stumps.

In fact, it was the East’s first innings story in a nutshell, batters getting dismissed before the innings reached the full bloom.

Easwaran, who is often dubbed as an obdurate batter, looked in complete control, and at times even outpaced Sooryavanshi.

They milked 100 runs for the opening wicket in just 14.overs and East seldom let that momentum slip.

Sooryavanshi would curse himself for playing a rather reckless pull off Milind for

substitute Tanay Thayagarajan to offer a simple catch in the deep.

It, perhaps, was the first time South bowlers tested the young left-hander with a short-pitched ball and it yielded instant results.

The whole sequence will teach the Bihar youngster to show more patience in the middle, particularly when nearly 10,000 spectators thronged the MA Chidambaram Stadium to watch the latest wonder kid in cricket.

Kushagra too played with determination as South withered under a barrage of runs.

Nothing more revealed the plight of South than the sight of lead pacer Mohammad

Siraj going through three colourless spells.

The India quick’s outing on the day read - 5-0-41-0, 5-1-24-0 and 4-0-31-0 for an overall reading of 14-1-96-0. Siraj was clobbered around by Sooryavanshi (6, 4, 4), Easwaran (4, 4), Kushagra (6, 4) as the Hyderabad man struggled to make an impact.

He can partly blame a flat pitch for his ineffectiveness, but there was no real attempt from his side to alter the course of the happenings.

Unless, South find a way to pluck East’s remaining six wickets on Monday quickly they will be further buried under an avalanche of runs, and will find it tough to come out of it. (PTI)

The Baby Boss vibe: Fans soak in Sooryavanshi appearance at Chepauk

G UNNIKRIISHNAN
■ Chennai

‘Vaibhav bhai, Vaibhav ji, Vaibhav.’

The roar reached a crescendo as Sooryavanshi walked to the fence to greet fans, who have been waiting since Sunday morning to have a closer look at the latest cricketing darling.

The Tamil Nadu Cricket Association opened the lower stands in the C, D and E blocks at the MA Chidambaram Stadium here free of cost for the Duleep Trophy final between South Zone and East Zone.

But they would not have expected nearly 12000 spectators to rush to fill those decks. It’s a rare sight in domestic cricket these days,



and often confined to the romantics’ memories from the 80s or 90s.

The last time such a frenzy was witnessed was on January 30, 2025 when Virat Kohli turned out for Delhi in a Ranji Trophy match after 12

those two icons have managed during their illustrious careers.

But an explosive IPL 2026 has given the 15-year-old the kind of stardom only a select few has enjoyed in Indian cricket. For someone like England’s Jos Buttler, Sooryavanshi is destined to break all T20 records and for Krishnamachari Srikkanth, the Bihar boy will infuse more life into Test cricket in near future.

For his East Zone skipper Ishan Kishan, Sooryavanshi is “very smart for a 15-year-old boy” who already knows inside out of his life and career. But there is this boyish impishness still simmering under that collected exterior.

It oozed out when he ham-

mered senior India pacer Mohammad Siraj for a six and two fours in an over.

Siraj and fellow quick MD Nideesh tested him with a few snorters early in the first session but the left-hander ducked or weaved away from them.

The Hyderabad man soon changed the angle of attack - much fuller, dangerously close to Sooryavanshi’s hitting arc.

The batter exploited to the hilt, eking out a total of three boundaries and a maximum. From 11 off 14 balls, Sooryavanshi soon moved to 34 off 24 balls.

The 93-minute show, which kept the rooting fans delirious, eventually ended when Sooryavanshi pulled CV Milind to substitute fielder

Tanay Thyagarajan in the deep. However, the crowd did not disperse. They waited till the end of the day to chant his name incessantly, prompting Sooryavanshi to spend a few minutes with the eager fans.

So, how does Sooryavanshi take in all this adulation, the status of national crush?

“He is a down to earth person. He does not think much about all this and thinks only about his cricket. It’s nice to have him in the dressing room,” said Shikhar Mohan, his East Zone teammate after the day’s play.

But that moment transpired under the fading Chennai sun made one thing clear - Vaibhav era has just begun. (PTI)

We plan together: Charani on India’s strategy in Pakistan rout



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

Young left-arm spinner Shree Charani, whose incisive spell helped India dismantle Pakistan in their Women’s T20 Asia Cup clash, said the team’s slow bowlers map out their strategy together before matches and then focus on executing it as well as possible.

Charani (3/7), Prema Rawat (3/9) and Deepti Sharma (2/5) combined to choke the life out of Pakistan’s batting, bowling them out for their lowest-ever T20I total of 55 before India cruised to a seven-wicket win with 68 balls to spare on Saturday.

India, who had already secured a semifinal berth from Group A before the match, finished on top with six points after winning all three of their games.

“In the meeting, we three sit together... Prema, me, Deepti di and Radha (Yadav) di and we discuss what to do (in the match). So, we just try to implement that here (on the field) whatever Deepti and Radha di say,” said Charani, who wreaked havoc on Pakistan’s top order, dismissing Shawaal Zulfiqar,

Gull Feroza, and Ayesha Zafar, after Shafali Verma had provided India with the first breakthrough by removing Muneeba Ali.

Charani’s double strike in the sixth over left Pakistan reeling at 29/3 after they had raced to 27 without loss, and they never recovered from the setback.

The 22-year-old spinner, who is just one wicket away from completing a half-century of T20I wickets, attributed her success to keeping things simple and focusing on getting the basics right.

“It’s just about myself. Like I just want to focus on my things... I want to do my things correct,” she said.

Charani said that after assessing the pitch and sensing that it would offer turn, she simply focused on bowling at the stumps and let the ball do the rest.

“I just tried to bowl on the stumps. By seeing the pitch, we know it may turn so I just focused on that.”

Charani also heaped praise on Prema, whose sharp leg-breaks left Pakistan’s batters struggling, describing her as a naturally gifted cricketer capable of excelling in all departments of the game.

Misbah complains about differential treatment of coaches in Pakistan cricket

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

Former Test captain Misbah-ul-Haq, who recently stepped down as national selector, has complained about differential treatment meted out to foreign and local coaches in Pakistan cricket. Misbah, who offered to resign as national selector after the Pakistan Cricket Board issued a notice to the selectors after the national team shake-up in England, said foreign coaches enjoyed more authority and power.

“It is a fact that local and foreign coaches are treated differently in Pakistan cricket. Local coaches have to face more scrutiny and criticism when compared to foreign coaches,” Misbah

said on a television show.

“I don’t think there is anything wrong in having foreign coaches but what bothers me is we (fans, critics, media, PCB) tend to have a soft corner for foreign coaches,” he added.

He said more authority was given to foreign coaches.

“We tend to give foreign coaches more authority and power and he is held less responsible if the team performs poorly. In contrast, local coaches always facing scrutiny from everyone.”

Misbah said Pakistani cricket fans, critics, former players and board need to offer more support to local coaches and not just criticise them for the sake.

He also felt that there is a



negative trend nowadays in Pakistan cricket to start bashing players and put them down mentally after any poor show.

“It becomes very difficult for our players to regain form and confidence.”

He said Pakistan cricket’s

main issue was the need to have more consistency, patience and a long-term plan. “We shouldn’t panic and do cosmetic surgery because of pressure. We need to analyse performances and the situation and then decide how to

move forward,” Misbah said.

“Unfortunately we are used to taking reactive decisions in Pakistan cricket.”

The PCB changed seven players in the touring squad in England and also released Sarfaraz Ahmed and Umar Gul - their head coach and bowling coach, respectively - for the third and final Test against England at Edgbaston following a harrowing 194-run defeat which sealed the Test series 2-0 in the favour of the hosts.

The selectors were also asked to explain why axed players Imam-ul-Haq and Mohammad Rizwan were picked in the touring squad and the criteria for selection.

Misbah said Indian cricket had moved forward because they didn’t panic and stuck

to their plans. He gave examples of Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli in the Indian cricket set-up.

He said the reason India was now dominating Pakistan in cricket was because their players had more exposure and were professionally and mentally strong to perform under pressure. “Our youngsters are playing too much white-ball cricket and their exposure to red-ball cricket is limited. Not enough four-day cricket. This means they have more chances of cracking under pressure.

“India took time to process and develop and they made gradual investments in their system after the 90s. There is no quick fix to the system.”

Iva Jovic ends Alex Eala’s US Open to set up a matchup against fellow American Coco Gauff

STEPHEN WHYNO
■ New York

Iva Jovic needed more than three hours to end Alex Eala’s run at the US Open.

Coco Gauff is up next, with a spot in the quarterfinals at stake. Jovic beat Eala 7-5, 3-6, 7-5 in a three-hour, three-set, back-and-forth showcase of stars inside Arthur Ashe Stadium on Saturday night.

“That felt like a marathon, and I felt like I lost my sanity five times over to win that match,” Jovic said. “But it’s really worth it for this feeling. I’m usually not one that shows that many emotions, but this



one really meant a lot to me. It’s everything to have another match here at the US Open.”

The 18-year-old American acknowledged the crowd not always being on her side against Eala, a fan favorite from the Philippines, whose

fervent following has become one of the biggest storylines in the sport. But she rallied from down 4-2 in the third set and got a hearty ovation after finishing it off and falling to the court. Jovic has made another deep run at a Grand Slam

after reaching the fourth round at Wimbledon and the French Open and making the quarter-finals at the Australian Open. She lost to Jessica Pegula in London, Naomi Osaka in Paris and Aryna Sabalenka in Melbourne.

Now, she and Gauff are among the five US women’s players left, along with Pegula, Taylor Townsend and Emma Navarro.

“Obviously, there’s a lot of pressure here as an American trying to do well,” Gauff said after beating Cristina Bucsa earlier Saturday. “Everybody wants to win this tournament, but I think for Americans it’s even more special.” (AP)

Messi logs two assists for Inter Miami in first match since retiring from international soccer

ALANIS THAMES
■ Miami

Lionel Messi may have retired from international soccer, but he’s certainly not done making an impact on the pitch. Messi had two assists for Inter Miami on Saturday night as his MLS club played Atlanta United to a 2-2 draw in his first match since announcing that his time playing for his native Argentina is done.

Luis Suarez and Casemiro scored for Inter Miami, which is second in the Eastern Conference and 10 points behind first-place Nashville



with 11 matches left in the regular season. Casemiro headed home a corner from Messi to open the scoring in the 32nd minute. Miguel Almiron equalized for Atlanta a couple minutes later before Messi lofted a pass toward Telasco Segovia, who set up

Suarez’s 12th goal of the season - a right-footed shot from the center of the box just before halftime.

Breel Embolo, converted a penalty in the 87th, and Atlanta withstood a series of last-minute chances by Inter Miami for the draw.

On a rainy night at Inter Miami’s Nu Stadium, fans cheered when players from both clubs came out for warm-ups after inclement weather caused a delay of more than an hour - and they roared even louder when Messi emerged from the tunnel. “Very emotional,” midfielder Rodrigo De Paul said in Spanish during a pre-match interview with Apple TV. “We lived with so much excitement having him out there on the field. It brought us so much joy to see the Argentina jersey all over the world, and it always had a No. 10 on the back.” (AP)

Martinez leads Inter comeback over Napoli, Musiala returns for Bayern

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

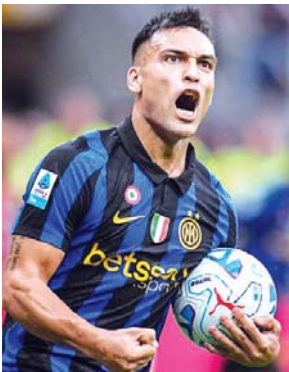
Lautaro Martinez struck a second goal in injury time to complete Inter Milan’s 3-2 comeback win over title rival Napoli in Serie A on Saturday, while Jamal Musiala returned to the field for Bayern Munich in a scoreless draw with Schalke.

Musiala played his first minutes in the Bundesliga this season after the Bayern midfielder had collapsed in two preseason games

because of a neurological issue which causes seizures.

In Spain, Athletic Bilbao struck three times in the second half to beat Diego Simeone’s Atletico Madrid 3-0 in La Liga, while Erling Haaland led Manchester City to another victory in the Premier League.

It was a night of comebacks in Serie A, with Roma joining Inter with a dramatic two-goal rally in the dying minutes that kept the teams at the top of the standings with three wins in as many



rounds. Martinez’s goals ensured that Inter kept up its

early title defense. Napoli looked to be comfortably in charge after Matteo Politano and Rasmus Hojlund scored in the 50th and 53rd minutes.

But Martinez pulled one back three minutes later and Marcus Thurman equalized in the 82nd just moments after hitting the post. Martinez found the winner after Manuel Akanji scrambled a loose ball to him at the far post to poke home, unleashing celebrations at San Siro. Napoli, under new coach Massimiliano Allegri, has now

lost two in a row after falling to Como. Next up for Inter is a trip to Real Madrid in their Champions League opener on Tuesday. Matias Soule led Roma with a late assist and goal to beat Atalanta 2-1.

The forward set up Mario Hermoso in the 90th, canceling out the opener by Ederson. Soule then struck three minutes into stoppage time to grab the victory. Torino beat Fiorentina 2-1 away. Musiala went on as a second-half substitute in Bayern’s 0-0 draw with Schalke.

India blank Bangladesh 3-0, await AFC U20 Asian Cup qualification fate

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Tashkent (Uzbekistan)

A dominant India blanked Bangladesh 3-0 in their final group match of the AFC U20 Asian Cup Qualifiers here on Sunday, for their second win of the tournament.

The victory took India to six points from three matches. Their fate, however, now depends on the outcome of the Syria-Uzbekistan match later on



Sunday. If Syria fail to defeat Uzbekistan, the Blue Colts will finish second in Group B and qualify for the AFC U20 Asian Cup main tournament after 20 years as one of the seven best runners-up teams

across the eight groups.

Danny Meitei Laishram opened the scoring in the 25th minute before Vishal Yadav doubled India’s advantage with an acrobatic finish on the hour mark. Substitute Md Arbash then sealed the contest with a powerful strike in the 79th minute. The match began on an even keel, with neither side able to establish control during the opening exchanges.